

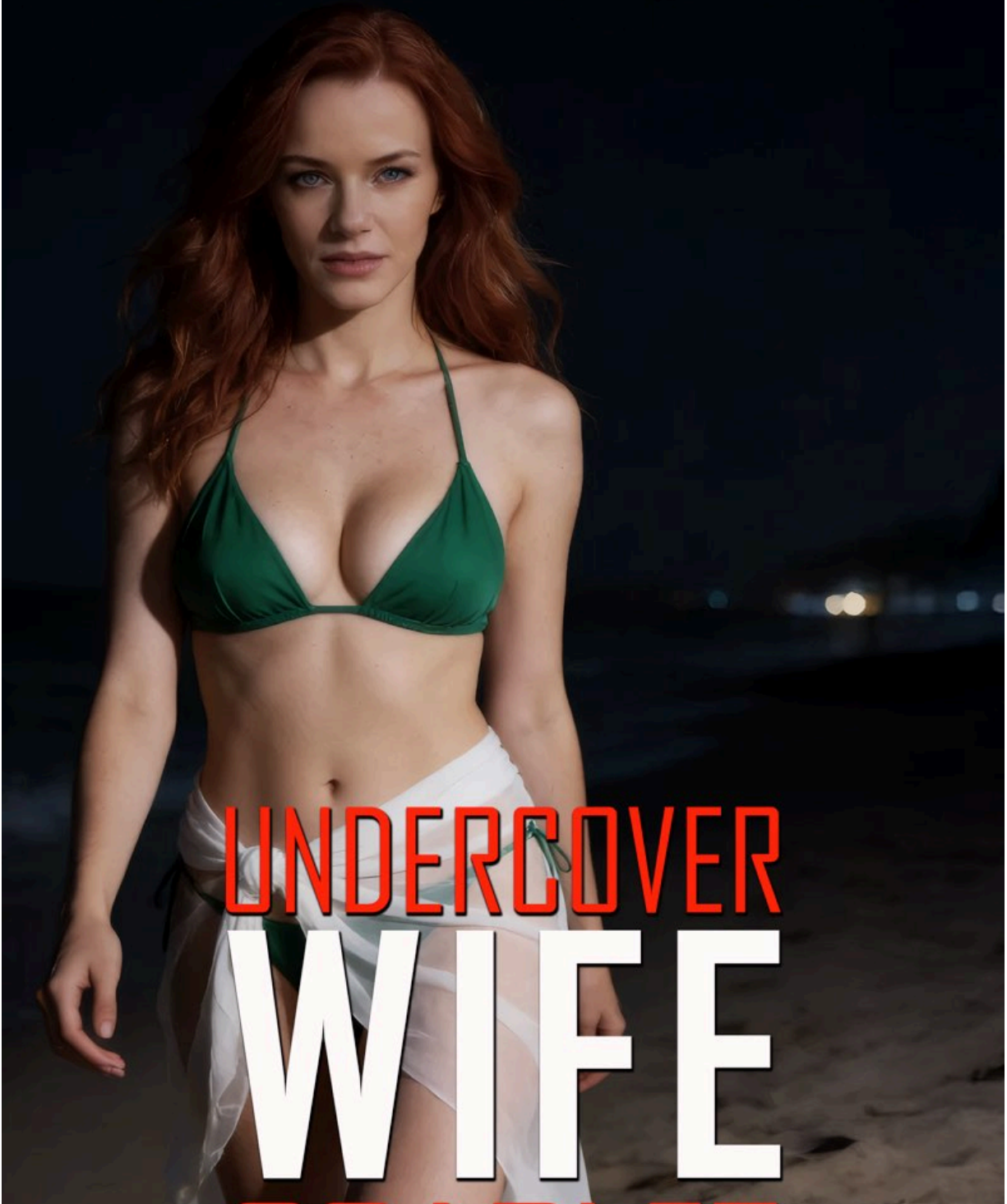
APHRODITE  OMNIMEDIA

BESTSELLING AUTHOR
KIRSTEN MCCURRAN

UNDERCOVER
WIFE
SCARLET
PHANTOM

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**undercover wife: scarlet
phantom**

kirsten mcurran

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UNDERCOVER WIFE: SCARLET PHANTOM

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previously...

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Former CIA field officer Madison Sinclair has been working a desk in Langley for the past sixteen years. She left the danger and excitement of covert missions behind when she met the love of her life, Charles Sinclair, and chose to start a family over the thrill of using her mind *and body* in the field. Madison has settled into a comfortable suburban life in McLean, VA—two kids, soccer games and school plays, a nice house, and membership in local clubs. Madison doesn't miss the old life because she chooses not to think about it.

All of that changes when Madison is called to Deputy Director Jennifer Bristow's office. A dangerous new cyberthreat to the United States has arisen, Null:Echo, and her nation needs Madison's help to stop it.

The quantum cipher key can hack any system in seconds, completely undetected. And the Russian hacker group that built it, Glacier Flame, is about to sell Null:Echo to the highest bidder, which will undoubtedly be the Middle Eastern nation of Kharabat, a major state sponsor of terror groups around the world.

The CIA needs someone to get close to Prince Zaydan bin Zaman Al-Kharabati and stop the deal. Madison is uniquely qualified. The young prince has certain tastes in women, older, married women ripe for seduction, and Madison fits the bill. After sixteen years on a desk at

Langley, she knows she's unprepared for such a dangerous and unpredictable mission, but Bristow makes it clear there is no other choice.

Madison meets the team for what has been dubbed Operation Scarlet Phantom: Cassandra Gale, the ambitious young officer acting as handler for the mission, Tayshawn "Tay" Dentinger, a brutal and resourceful field officer with an axe to grind against Madison, Manny Sanz, one of the Wizards from the CIA's technical division, and the man who will be acting as Madison's husband while undercover, Damien Kane.

Madison hasn't seen Kane in sixteen years, not since their last mission together, which left them both shot and clinging to life. But Madison and Kane were more than partners, and when she chose Charles, it meant not choosing Kane. As if their steamer trunk full of baggage weren't an issue that could derail the mission, Madison needs to walk the line between building believable chemistry with Kane and not crossing a line that will betray her marriage.

Kane and Madison become David and Michelle Richardson and gain membership to Nox Venari, the exclusive, international sex club for the world's famous and elite, and where the deal for Null:Echo is scheduled to happen. It's time for Madison to unearth the seductive vixen buried beneath the suburban mom and wrap Prince Zaydan around her finger and obtain Null:Echo for the good guys.

The plan goes better than the Operation Scarlet Phantom team could have hoped. After an initial meet-cute, Zaydan can't get enough of Madison. It seems like his life's goal is to get into the reticent suburban mom's pants. With her own personal experience, Madison plays the role of Melissa Richardson to perfection. She teases the young prince just enough to keep him on the hook without giving it up too fast.

Everything is going perfectly until a familiar face arrives on the scene.

Madison's blood runs cold when she sees Sergei Reznikov, the son of the man she killed on her final field mission sixteen years ago. But the

shocks keep coming. Madison learns that Sergei's father, Anatoly Reznikov is very much alive!

Suddenly, Operation Scarlet Phantom become more deadly than anyone could have guessed.

THESE EVENTS all take place in *Undercover Wife: Null:Echo*, now available in ebook and paperback wherever books are sold.

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Aegean Sea

MADISON SUNNED herself on the top deck of the *Aurelius*, skin glistening under the brutal Mediterranean sun. She kept the sunblock close to hand as she baked in the heat. In the month she'd been with Gunter Müller, wanted to believe that she'd developed a nice base tan, but she still cringed when she thought about what the sun's rays were doing to her.

Normally, she didn't expose an inch of her pale, Irish skin to the sun if she didn't have to. Even at twenty-five, she had enough sense to know she didn't want to look like a leather handbag in twenty years. But lying in the sun on the upper deck of the *Rheingold* was part of the gig. The surface gig anyway.

The month-long contract with Gunnar Müller had been brokered by Mal Sewell, an agent who specialized in connecting aspiring young models—usually pretty girls with little to no modeling experience—with the wealthy businessmen who were looking for no-fuss companionship that couldn't say no.

Madison was playing the role of Eileen Monahan, a wide-eyed college student who'd been enjoying a semester abroad in London when she was scouted by Mal in a Kensington pub. Eileen was a Boston girl—the cover wasn't much of a stretch—who'd done some catalog work for Filene's back home and needed cash to pay for school.

Eileen may have been naïve enough to buy Mal's pitch and accompany him to Munich to meet a potential client, but what the job offer actually entailed became clear when she was introduced to Müller in a seedy, smoky Munich nightclub.

The middle-aged German man had openly stared at her as soon as she walked in the door with Mal. Like a lot of wealthy men, he didn't pretend that beautiful women weren't another commodity to him, or that there was another reason for their transaction. Mal's Cockney accent grew thicker as he tried to soft-pedal what would be expected of her, but Müller was not interested in pretense.

"Do you have much experience with this sort of thing?" Müller asked. They'd been in the VIP section of the balcony, and somehow the German's booming voice carried over the bass-heavy dance music spun by the DJ below.

Madison told him about Eileen's catalog work for Filene's. The man's condescending chuckle made her want to punch him in the throat, but the CIA had trained her well, and she smiled coquettishly.

"Did my friend Mal not explain the job to you, Eileen? This is not a modeling job. You will be a massage therapist servicing my guests and myself. We'll leave next week and travel to my yacht in Greece."

Madison—as Eileen—shot a look at Mal. The handsome man managed to look embarrassed.

"I said it wasn't strictly a modeling gig, didn't I, luv?" Mal grinned like a man accustomed to smoothing over misunderstandings with his rough charm.

“I don’t have any professional massage experience,” Madison protested.

“Training will be provided. Technical skill is less important than your other attributes,” Müller explained, staring right down her cleavage.

“I don’t know about this,” she replied. Of course, while Eileen wasn’t convinced, Madison had to get onto that yacht. She just couldn’t come across as too eager. She thought she’d done an excellent job. It wasn’t just her tits that had gotten her to Greece.

The op with Gunnar Müller was Madison’s fourth deep cover job for the Agency. She’d been recruited fresh out of college and had been in the field for a couple of years now, but it already felt like she’d been doing fieldwork for an eternity.

Her early assignments had been much more straightforward. She started out monitoring comms on other officers’ missions, doing dead drops, and spending endless, tedious hours surveilling targets. She hadn’t expected the assignments to be non-stop James Bond stuff, but she also hadn’t expected it to be so mind-numbing. There were hours and hours where nothing happened, punctuated by moments of excitement. She needed more excitement. She hadn’t joined the CIA to leave newspapers on park benches and sit in vans that reeked of sweat and farts.

Everything changed after 9/11. Priorities shifted, and everyone in the intelligence services shed boundaries—personal and moral—that they never imagined they would. But no one questioned the mission. Protecting the homeland and punishing those who attacked America were the only two jobs that mattered.

Madison wiped sweat from her forehead and sat up on the chaise. She felt the weight of Tilo’s gaze on her tits from where he leaned against the wet bar across the deck. His dark sunglasses didn’t hide anything.

Tilo, a lower-level thug, was often left behind to guard the girls. The deadly bodyguards travelled with Müller when he went ashore. Even though it was lower status, she suspected Tilo preferred his assignment. She

drained her champagne glass and waggled it for the bodyguard. He was also there to take care of Müller's girls' needs. He seemed to resent that part of the job.

"Would you?" she asked in German, intentionally butchering the pronunciation. Madison spoke fluent German with a Berlin accent, but Eileen only knew the bits she'd picked up over the past month. She turned to the women on either side of her and asked in English, "Do you girls need a refill?"

Yuki, to her right, was on her stomach, her tight, tanned ass on full display. She didn't even bother with the pretense of her bikini bottoms. Her waist-length black hair was tucked up under a hat. She told Madison no without even lifting her head. Like the girl to Madison's left, she spoke enough English to communicate with the American.

Farah, to her left, drained the rest of her flute, shrugged, and purred, "Why not?" She was, perhaps, the most beautiful woman Madison had ever seen. The Moroccan beauty had thick dark hair with perfect blonde streaks and the kind of curves that had inspired a thousand Renaissance painters. Her large breasts, which spilled to the side while she was reclining on the chaise, were so perfect that even Madison wanted to caress them.

"Farah, too. Could you bring us water, too, please?" Madison called out to Tilo.

"The bar is right here, Eileen. You can come and get it yourself. I'm not a waiter."

Sometimes Tilo chafed at his role looking after the women on Müller's yacht, despite the obvious perks. Madison didn't entirely blame him. He wasn't a butler. Of course, he was arguing because he wanted to watch her walk across the deck.

Smiling sweetly, she rose from the chaise and strutted across the deck toward the young, burly bodyguard. Learning to be comfortable as she walked around essentially naked—she only wore the tiniest string bikini

bottom—had been a process. Madison was comfortable with her body, but she didn't openly display it the way Müller liked. Her employer didn't like tan lines either, which was why she was topless, even when he wasn't on the yacht. The process started at that club back in Munich.

"Let me see," Müller had said on that smoky balcony. "I need to see before anything is signed."

"Excuse me?" Madison-as-Eileen had replied with indignation.

"We are talking about a lot of money. I would like to see if you are worth it. I know the tricks undergarments can play."

The irony was that wearing a bra under her short, sparkly silver dress was impossible, which she was sure Müller knew. He wanted to see her tits, but it was about more than that. Her hotness was secondary to her ability to do as she was told. A man like Gunnar Müller didn't pay €10,000 a week just for a nice pair of tits.

Madison had stared at Mal, who'd shrugged again and said, "Go on, luv. Forty thousand euros for a month of your time is a lot of money. He's only asking for a look at your tits. How many times have you pulled them out for free?"

She'd glared at Mal, and it hadn't been solely playacting as Eileen. Madison was annoyed that he was so cavalier with her body. She'd hoped he'd at least pretend to stand up for her for a second, but then a sleaze like Mal wouldn't, would he? Besides, he wanted to see her tits as much as the German did.

They'd discussed enough at that point that even a nice, middle-class girl like Eileen knew she was not being paid that kind of money to be a pretty masseuse. Either she was desperate enough for the money to sell herself for €40,000 a month, or she wasn't. There would be paperwork. No one was going to bundle her into the trunk of a car and cart her off to Greece.

With a huff, Madison reached for the straps of her pretty little party dress. Müller had stopped her. "Stand, please. I want to see properly."

Madison had cast off the last shred of Eileen's dignity, stood, and peeled the dress down over her chest. It took effort to pull it past her breasts, which had popped free. The dimly lit club had been humid and still, but her thick, pale nipples still crinkled and darkened under Müller's gaze.

"Yes?" the German had said, spinning his hand in a gesture indicating that she should keep going. He'd smiled; he had liked what he'd seen so far.

In for a penny, in for a pound, she'd thought, stepping closer to her prospective benefactor. *He might as well get a good look if I'm doing this. €40,000 is a lot of money.* The sum was far more than her actual salary from the Agency.

Madison had wiggled her hips and rolled the dress past them, letting it drop to the floor. She'd been left in a scrap of black lace that passed for a G-string. She hadn't expected anyone to see her in it when she'd picked it. She just hadn't wanted panty lines with the dress. Feeling ridiculous standing there stiffly with her body exposed in a public place, Madison had started moving to the DJ's beat.

Madison's Irish Catholic mother had drummed the rules for being a 'proper girl' into her, despite her own noticeable lack of chastity, and the constant push-pull of morality vs. her desires had carried into her adulthood. It had impacted most of Madison's interactions with boys.

And that was why she'd been so surprised when the shame of displaying herself—she owned her sexuality, but she didn't flaunt it—had begun to melt away. She felt the eyes of the men around her, and the sway she had over them gave Madison a charge she'd never felt before. Her core tightened in response, and she prayed the men couldn't see how aroused she was becoming.

Müller had looked like he wanted to hand her €40,000 on the spot. His personal bodyguard—Felix, she'd learned later—had a predatory look that sent chills down her spine, in both good *and* bad ways. Felix was a hard-

looking man about Müller's age who was ruthlessly efficient and seemed to enjoy cruelty.

Beside her, Mal threw off so much heat that Madison had been afraid he would burn her if he touched her. Mal definitely looked like he wanted to keep Eileen for himself. She might not have minded that. And then there were the other men in the VIP lounge, standing in a corner by the railing that overlooked the dance floor below—and they weren't alone in the balcony. Madison had never displayed herself for so many men like that.

After all of that, on a sun-soaked ship in the Mediterranean, it was easy to smile at Tilo as his head bobbed along with the bounce of her full breasts, and his smile widened as she got closer. Madison smiled back. She was not the same woman who'd signed on to go to Greece with Gunnar Müller for a month. As she'd leaned into her role as Eileen Monahan, a new, sexually confident Madison had emerged. She wasn't even intimidated by Farah's and Yuki's beauty anymore—well, almost.

She reached over the bar for a bottle of water, letting her bare breasts brush Tilo's arm. He was allowed to wear a black sport shirt and khaki pants for deck duty—showing off his extensive arm tattoos—instead of his usual blazer, so the hair on his arms tickled her nipples. It wasn't unpleasant, but more importantly, it distracted Tilo. Her work was easier when he was distracted.

“Now that I'm standing, I suppose I'll go below and freshen up,” she sweetly told him.

Tilo grunted, staring at her slick tits. She knew he desperately wanted to grab them. Word was that Müller occasionally rewarded his men with time with his girls, but she hadn't seen it in the time she'd been on the *Rheingold*.

“Don't fall asleep down there,” Tilo said. “Herr Müller will be back soon. He won't want you asleep when he returns.”

“Yes, sir,” she replied, firing off a tight salute.

Madison let Tilo watch her butt as she walked back to the chaise to fetch the bag she'd brought up to the deck; she bent deep at the waist to give him a really good show. Her earbuds went in, and she clicked play on her iPod. Queens of the Stone Age filled her ears. When she walked past him again to reach the stairs, she winked, hoping he caught it behind her sunglasses.

That should keep his mind off his work for a while, she thought.

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Madison made a quick pit stop in one of the *Rheingold*'s eight bathrooms to slip on her bikini top. She tied the white bikini top in place—all the swimwear provided for the girls was white—but there was no way for it to fully cover her chest. She washed her hands thoroughly, making sure all the sweat and lotion were cleaned away. The next steps were delicate.

Her earbuds remained in place, but the music was off. She needed to hear what was happening around her. She was a deck lower, near the aft end of the yacht, where Müller's office was located. Madison untwisted her lipstick and got to work. The lock yielded easily to the tools contained inside her tube of MAC Freckle.

A custom terminal connected via secure satellite uplink sat on the small glass desk; Müller used it to conduct his transactions and monitor his money. She opened the false bottom in her iPod—custom build by the wizards in DS&T—unwound the cable concealed there, and connected it to the terminal. The device did the rest.

While she waited, Madison idly wondered if the decrypting technology would ever get fast enough that she wouldn't be risking her life every time she tried to hack into a system. The iPod both bypassed the terminal's security so that she could view its contents and copied the records into its memory.

The next time Madison was on land, she was expected to hand the iPod off to another officer so the Agency could review the data. She would receive an identical device in return. If she saw something urgent in the financial records, she was expected to find a way to send a signal ashore.

Madison was relieved she hadn't found anything that required the latter. Müller's security was tight. She had no idea how she would get a signal to the officers on land. More than once, she'd nearly been caught passing off the iPod.

Opening the terminal to Müller's most recent transactions, she scanned the lines that ended in eye-popping sums. All the accounts were listed solely by numbers, but Madison had memorized the accounts the Agency was looking for. Money moving in or out of those accounts likely meant that a terrorist organization was planning an operation soon. That was exactly the sort of thing that would require she signal the shore.

One of those accounts popped. \$7.3 million had been moved into one of Müller's equity funds from an account she knew was controlled by the Kharabati royal family. They were well-known funders of terror cells. The cash was moved back out into another numbered account in less than twenty-four hours. A group had the money they needed to finance an attack.

"Shit," she murmured to herself.

Madison didn't know who controlled the target account, but the Agency could find out. The top-secret bankers of Europe and the Virgin Islands began cooperating with the US on a limited basis after 9/11. They understood they had no choice. The United States was done fucking around.

The grayscale display on the iPod said the records transfer was only 60% complete. Madison sighed and impatiently tapped her sandaled foot on the carpet. She'd done everything she could to distract the guards on her way below decks, but they would start to wonder where she'd gone. Tilo might even stick his head into the cabin she shared with Yuki and Farah to

make sure she hadn't fallen asleep against his advice. He was always finding excuses to intrude on their living quarters.

Pacing the office, she perused the art on the walls. *Art* was a strong word, in her opinion. The works adorning Müller's office were charcoal renderings of large-breasted women in various erotic poses with well-endowed mythic creatures. Some of the images were more abstract than others, but one featured a woman who bore a striking resemblance to Heidi Klum facing off with a minotaur's phallus that would quite literally be impossible to take. The supermodel looked more intrigued than horrified.

What is she supposed to do with that? Madison wondered. *Take up baseball?* She was sure that Herr Müller had imagined what came next many times.

Another print showed a curvy Medusa confronting a man with a lion's head and another huge cock. Her snakes had only turned part of him to stone. A curvy woman lay before him with legs spread, ready to be split in two.

Madison knew all too well that Müller enjoyed testing women's limits, but fortunately, he'd never broken out anything that large. She would have had to dive overboard. There was a limit to what she was willing to do for her country.

She froze at the sound of an approaching helicopter. She was out of time. Müller was returning, and she had to be on deck. He liked to have his girls there to greet him—especially when he had company, which he may very well have brought board. The German had been tense in the last few days—probably because of the Kharabati transaction.

Scrambling behind the desk, blind luck meant that Madison saw the display click to 100% just before she pulled the cable from the terminal. Finished or not, she was out of time.

Tobias, another member of the *Rheingold's* security detail, called out her name. He sounded like he was still on the steps. Madison stuffed the

cable into the iPod and clicked the false bottom into place. She made for the door.

“Eileen, why are you down here? You’re not to be on this level with an escort,” Tobias called out from the bottom of the steps. His perfect English was tinged with a softened German accent.

Madison did her best to blush and smiled, batting her eyes at the large man. “I’m sorry. I thought I left my underwear down here, and I just wanted to see if the door was unlocked.”

She’d had barely enough time to move away from Müller’s office and stand by the door to his playroom. The previous evening had been quite memorable, and she very well could have lost her panties in the playroom—if she’d been wearing any.

Tobias roughly seized her arm. “You should have asked one of us to bring you down.”

“Do you think I want to tell any of you that I can’t keep track of my panties, Tobias?”

“That is not the point, Eileen. Coming down here is...”

The thug was probably about to tell Madison that her presence was *verboten*, but when he jostled Madison, her bikini top came free, and her tits shook loose. Tobias was the sternest of Müller’s men, beside Felix, the German’s personal bodyguard, but even he was stopped in his tracks by the sight of Madison’s perfect, pert breasts. Sometimes she thought they had hypnotic powers. They’d been rendering men speechless for almost a decade.

“I’m sorry, Tobias. I know I was naughty,” she replied, pressing her chest into his and touching his arm. He was a full head taller than she was, and it was like pushing against a brick wall.

“Herr Müller would not be pleased to know you were down here unescorted. His office is right down the hallway.”

Tobias stared like he was amazed by the way her breasts pushed up and expanded when she mashed them into him. He had to feel how hard her nipples were through his tight shirt. Madison was a little ashamed by how much she liked rubbing against a man like Tobias.

“We don’t have to tell anyone, do we? I promise to be a *very* good girl from now on, Tobias.” She squeezed his arm. It felt like trying to squeeze a telephone pole. Her other hand brushed the front of his khakis. They were stretched tight.

It might not be the worst thing in the world if I had to give him a serious bribe. Madison had no doubt he could give her what she needed. She’d gotten off many times since she’d been employed by the German, but not from anything like what Tobias was packing. Müller preferred other methods of pleasure.

Madison stepped back so her breasts could drop fully into his view. Her bikini hung uselessly just below them. Tobias crowded her back against the wall, his hand on her hip. She thought he might rip away her bikini bottom, too. He was breathing heavily.

Was he calculating if he had enough time to throw a quick fuck into her? *Come on, take me, you bastard,* she thought. Her core clenched despite the danger—or maybe because of it. She was beginning to like her work a little too much.

“Just get upstairs, Eileen. Herr Müller will want you there with the others when he lands,” he choked out.

Tobias turned Madison and pushed her forward with his massive paw on her ass. She knew he wanted to fuck her, but she still wasn’t sure if he was going to rat her out.

MADISON, Farah, and Yuki lined up on the deck, topless and smiling for Müller and his guest, a slender, fidgety Middle Eastern man in black slacks and a beige sports shirt. The German's guest was reserved, but his dark eyes swept over all the flesh on display with a hunger that raised the hairs on the back of Madison's neck.

Müller's associate was introduced as Tarik. The other girls accepted the man by his single moniker, but Madison knew he was Tarik al-Kharabati, a cousin of King Zaman al-Kharabati, the sovereign ruler of Kharabati. Tarik was the kingdom's primary contact with the terror groups they supported, which strengthened Madison's conviction that she had to act, no matter how risky it was. He could be whisked off to a CIA black site, and the Agency could extract what they needed to know.

Tarik was also a known religious zealot, but that didn't stop him from staring at the mostly-naked women. Madison did not sense that his intense gaze was steeped in disapproval.

Farah fetched them drinks while they sat on couches on a shaded part of the *Rheingold's* upper deck. Yuki was beside Müller, while Madison was squeezed in next to Tarik. The German was particularly fond of the beautiful Japanese woman, and his arm was slung over her shoulders. Yuki rested her hand on Müller's thigh, just short of where his cock lay. Tarik made no move to touch Madison and stiffened when she brushed her hand against his thigh. He did not, however, try to move away from her.

She reached across Tarik to take a mimosa from Farah, pressing her breasts firmly against him. It felt like he was all sharp edges and sinew under that shirt. The low sound that escaped his throat told Madison that he was certainly not as pious as his file suggested. When she leaned back, he shifted to keep their bodies in close contact. However, he declined a cocktail and asked for water.

Madison sensed their chat on the deck was not as light as it appeared on the surface. Müller seemed to be testing Tarik as much as she was. She'd

gotten to know the German well during her time on his yacht, and he'd want to know if Tarik was just another dry, humorless true believer or if he was a man Müller could trust on a human level. Müller preferred to do business with men he understood, men with tastes like his.

"Girls," Müller said in English, the one language they all shared. "Why don't we entertain our guest properly? I'm sure he'd love to see what you've learned in your time here."

Tarik's eyebrow went up. Madison's stomach clenched. She understood what their employer was asking for.

"You'd like us to put on a proper show?" Yuki asked, sliding her hand higher on Müller's thigh. She was certainly rubbing his cock now.

"*Ja*, my beauty," Müller replied. "Farah can show us what she's learned about Madison's body."

It was exactly what Madison expected, and she was *not* thrilled. She smiled, but not enthusiastically. She'd also learned that Müller enjoyed her apprehension.

"Would you gentlemen like to freshen up first? It's such a hot day," Madison said.

"I am very interested in this exhibition," Tarik answered for Müller. His clipped British accent betrayed his Eton education. "I see no reason for delay."

"Then Eileen and I will go down to the playroom. We'll be ready when you join us," Farah said.

Madison took Farah's offered hand and followed her below deck, steeling herself for what came next.

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“I’ll try to take it easy on you,” Farah said, tightening the cuff on Madison’s left wrist.

“He won’t let you, especially not with a guest to show off for.”

“Remember, Eileen. We’re putting on a show, even for him. It’s only as real as we choose to make it.”

Madison didn’t need to fake it. The degree to which she liked it scared her. She’d had no experience with things like restraints—or being with a woman—before she signed the contract with Müller and accompanied him to Greece. But what really made her heart race when she was restrained was the helplessness while undercover. Any day, she could be cuffed because Müller had found her out, not because he wanted to be entertained.

“I just hope he doesn’t drag it out all afternoon. I’m starving.”

“Do you want a quick bite before we start?”

Madison laughed. “I think this is best done on an empty stomach.”

Farah brushed back her fiery hair and said, “Good, because I wasn’t letting you up anyway.”

Sighing, Madison stared up at the low ceiling and hoped the men didn’t keep them waiting long. It was a strange position to be in. Nothing in her training at The Farm prepared her for being stripped and restrained at the

wrists and ankles on a luxury yacht. Her bikini—what there was of it—had been tossed into a corner.

The chill of the *Rheingold*'s air conditioning made her pale nipples peak into tight points. She wanted to cover them, but when she casually tested the white leather cuffs, they held her wrists fast. At least she could twist and close her legs to conceal her waxed pussy. Farah left one ankle uncuffed until the men arrived. Waxing was new to her, too. Müller insisted on it.

While they waited, Farah slipped on a pair of over-the-knee black patent leather boots with chrome spiked heels. They were the only thing she'd be wearing besides nipple clamps, which she carefully attached to her thick tips.

Voices in the hallway made Farah rush over and pull Madison's legs apart. She made an apologetic face when she pulled the strap as tight as she could before buckling it. Madison's thighs strained from being forced so wide open. She looked down between her breasts to see the hint of pink showing. She was truly helpless.

Yuki opened the door to the cabin and held it while the men filed in behind her. Felix stole a peek at Madison's spread form from the hallway before Yuki closed the door.

"Please, my friend, take a seat," Müller said, gesturing to the small couch that provided a perfect vantage point of the bed where Madison was displayed.

Tariq didn't seem to hear his host because he was so distracted by the pale redhead. He stared at her like he was judging who she was for allowing this to happen. His hard eyes said it was not a kind or favorable assessment.

Madison wanted to stab him for that look, even though she understood why he thought what he did. And of all men, Tariq al-Kharabati would judge her harshly.

"Is there anything in particular you want to see today, sir?" Farah asked, standing beside the bed with her hands clasped behind her back, which

made her tits jut out.

“Just get her started, dear,” Müller replied. “Then we’ll see if our guest has any requests. We have an array of implements Farah can use to pleasure Eileen.”

Tariq sat beside his host. “This is your circus, Herr Müller. I am content to observe. For now.”

Farah selected the Magic Wand to start. She always did. They’d done this about a dozen times for their employer’s amusement, but knowing what was coming didn’t make accepting it any easier.

The Magic Wand was a legendary sex toy, she’d learned. The white massager was heavy, with a long, corded handle containing the powerful motor, which was topped by a round, floating head. Madison had never seen one before her time on the *Rheingold*. It rumbled when Farah switched it on.

Madison flinched before it even touched her. The massager wouldn’t hurt—far from it—but she was barely used to Müller and the girls watching how it unraveled her. Allowing Tariq to see it felt so much worse. It was that look in his eyes—like he wanted to see Madison play the slut *and* punish her for it.

“Ahhh...Far...” she gasped when the wand grazed her lips. “Careful. Please. That thing is a beast.”

Farah smiled condescendingly. “I think I’ve proved I know what I’m doing, Eileen.”

The blunt, rumbling head brushed Madison’s sex again, then stayed in place. “Yes...mmm...you do...you do...ma’am...”

The tall, dark-haired beauty leaned over the bed and swept the wand across Madison’s mound in slow, practiced motions designed to torment with pleasure. Her heavy breasts swayed in the redhead’s face, the chain connecting her nipple clamps hanging low enough to brush Madison’s sensitive skin.

Fortunately, Müller was all about pleasure and its denial, not pain. But being denied for too long was its own kind of pain, Madison had learned.

She closed her eyes and fought her slow unraveling. Closing her eyes and regulating her breathing, Madison had learned that she could stave off the inevitable. She intentionally slowed her heartbeat. Surprisingly, the techniques the Agency taught her to resist enemy interrogations turned out to be just as effective in holding back when she didn't want to come too quickly.

Brushes with the rumbling massager became constant, shifting pressure, testing Madison's control. The pleasure radiated out from her center like the broadcast tower animations in old movies, and each successive wave nudged her closer and closer to an inevitable release.

"More," Müller demanded. "Show Tariq how easily Eileen loses control."

Madison took that personally. She was determined to prove to the sleazy German that she was in control of her body, not the other way around. She bit her lip, trying to suppress her moans, until she tasted the salty tang of her own blood. But when Farah applied serious pressure, turning up the wand and grinding it directly above her clit, a ragged cry escaped her throat, and her hips shifted at the tormenting toy.

"That's it. Why are you fighting it?" Farah cooed, her soft, accented voice rising above the growling sex toy. "We both know you can't hold out forever."

"I...ahhh...can... Mmmm....you're not the...ahhh...boss of me..."

Farah flicked a long, lacquered fingernail over Madison's swollen nipple. The redhead whimpered, and her tormentor kept plucking at the throbbing tip like she was playing a harp.

Madison was moaning rhythmically, losing the battle to manage her breathing. Her hips seemed to move of their own accord, rolling at the massager like she wanted to pull it inside her. As she struggled to keep her

head above the rising tide of pleasure, she wondered how many women the Magic Wand had ruined for men. She loved sex, but the core-deep orgasms that toy gave her were addictive.

“All of them, sluts,” Tariq commented under his breath.

“What was that?” Müller asked.

“Sluts. See how easily they surrender to a simple touch? This is why we protect them from their own lasciviousness and sin. So easily aroused. So easily pulled down.”

Tariq’s possessive stare spoke more to his own lasciviousness than hers. He was feeling something, but it was not purely anger at her sinfulness. The sweat on his upper lip and his shallow breathing suggested he wanted to cross the small cabin and teach Madison a lesson himself.

“I know plenty of men who are more easily undone by their urges than Eileen here,” Müller replied. “I think the struggle against our urges is a human struggle.”

“But women are the root of temptation. And their sin not only affects them but drags down the men around them. I know men are weak, but they are not responsible for the urges stirred in them by a sinful woman.”

Madison’s cries grew louder and louder, and the men had to raise their voices to speak over her.

“I respect your faith, but I believe we are all sinful by nature, if that even matters. I prefer to do what needs to be done, enjoy what I enjoy, and not analyze it any deeper. The analysis changes nothing,” Müller told his guest. “Perhaps you need help taking the edge off?”

The German gestured to Yuki, who’d been seated on the arm of the couch beside him, running her fingers through his hair, lightly raking her nails over his scalp. The girl knew what her master expected and slid from the couch to her knees in front of the men. She also understood hospitality and reached for the guest’s pants first.

Tariq stiffened and took a moment to appear conflicted before he allowed her to proceed. His dark cock was rigid and twitching, confirming how he felt about watching Madison be pleased by Farah. He moaned helplessly when Yuki stroked him, like the hand job was being inflicted upon him.

Once Tariq was dripping, Yuki shifted and freed Müller's cock. The men were a study in contrasts. Tariq's was dark and like steel, but otherwise slender and unimpressive. Müller was thicker and very pale, but he remained a touch spongy while Yuki played with his prick. Even when she took him in her mouth and sucked hard enough to hollow her cheeks, he stayed soft.

Madison was only vaguely aware of the men's conversation. She was too busy falling apart. Farah brought her right to the crest of her climax, only to snatch the massager away and leave her gasping and cursing.

"Ohhh goddam it! Stop teasing me...ahhh...you bitch..."

Farah ignored the heat in the epithet and laughed. "Patience, or it may not come at all."

"Not fair..." the redhead panted. *"I was...mmmm...right there..."*

"I know."

The leather restraints creaked when Madison pulled against them with all her strength. Her arms were taut, but neither the buckles on her cuffs nor the eyehooks holding the straps gave at all. She was sure she could pull herself free if she worked at it enough. She tried again before going limp with a frustrated groan and stared daggers at Farah.

Madison's fresh stream of invective was cut off when Farah kissed her. She melted under her tormentor's kiss. The raven-haired beauty had amazing, full lips and was one of the best kissers Madison had ever experienced. Farah made her wish she'd made out with girls sooner. She returned the kiss with serious heat and a lot of tongue, hoping it would encourage Farah to let her come.

Farah pressed the head of the wand back to Madison's mound and turned it up while they kissed. The redhead wailed into the kiss and her back bowed off the bed. The sudden pulse of pleasure was overwhelming. She twisted her mouth away from Farah's because she couldn't breathe.

"Ohmygod! Oh god...don't stop...let me come...please..." Madison cried, cursing herself for the *please* on the end.

Müller stroked Yuki's silky hair, but he never took his eyes off Madison. He appreciated the Asian woman's oral skills, but the main draw was watching a girl like the redhead unravel. He still remembered how she hesitated to show him her body in that nightclub in Munich, and now she was being sexually tormented to entertain him. Müller was proud that he'd remade her. Even a prig like Tariq had to appreciate what he'd done to Madison.

Yuki lifted her mouth from Müller, strings of saliva dripping back to his shaft. She gave her all to blowjobs. She turned back to Tariq, stretching out her tongue to lick up the precum she'd pumped out of him with her fist. Rather than letting Yuki work her magic, he planted his hand on the back of her head and pushed her mouth down onto his cock.

Müller did not want to criticize his associate—he made sizable commissions from moving money for the Kharabati royals—but he saw the man's impatience and general attitude toward women as weaknesses. Weaknesses that could be exploited if it came to it.

Tariq held the back of Yuki's head and thrust up into her mouth erratically and without control. Yuki gagged, but didn't attempt to pull away. Müller would make sure she was rewarded for her flexibility, and he would intervene if Tariq became too rough. Müller returned his attention to Madison. He could never keep his eye off her for long—especially when Farah was working her magic on the pretty American girl.

A tickle at the back of her brain told Madison to look over. Müller was watching closely. Their eye contact was unnerving. The man fed on her

helplessness, but she was more disturbed by her hunger for his arousal.

This assignment had taught the CIA officer that she liked strong men coveting her and taking what they wanted. Müller wasn't touching her, but they all knew that Farah was his instrument. Madison didn't need to fake anything to play the role of Eileen Monahan. The heat that Müller's possessive gaze sizzled through her was all too real.

Tariq was watching, too, while he fucked Yuki's mouth. His blend of desire and contempt triggered a different kind of intoxication, and suddenly Madison's orgasm was impossible to deny.

"Ahhh yesss...god yesss...fuck...I'm coming...ohmygod..."

The sharp cry was startling in the small cabin. Farah positioned the wand just right, keeping the intense climax rolling through Madison's body as she cried out over and over. Madison twisted so hard against the restraints that she nearly pulled her arm out of its socket. The rushing pleasure was almost too intense, but she was powerless to stop it.

"Mercy...please...I can't..." Madison begged.

"Oh, you can," Farah replied, grinning above her. "And you will, until Herr Müller tells me to stop."

"Fuck...you're going to kill me...I hate you..." Madison sobbed.

"Oh, you love it, Eileen," the woman replied, kissing her again.

Müller loved the intensity with which Madison came. She always completely surrendered to it, which made him surrender to his own pleasure. He grunted, and his cum spurted up and oozed down over Yuki's pumping fist. He would have liked to have finished in her mouth, but he couldn't wait, and Tariq was monopolizing it.

The Kharabati held Yuki's head with both hands now as he frantically fucked her throat. She made slurping sounds, trying to keep up, until he stopped suddenly and shuddered. His weak moan was almost mournful when he filled Yuki's mouth with his completion. He finally released her, and she sat back on her heels, flushed, drooling, and looking dazed.

“Should I stop, Herr Müller?” Farah asked.

“No, I believe Eileen deserves to come again. Make this one last. If you do a good job, she can pleasure you,” Müller replied.

Madison’s stomach flip-flopped. Farah was going to push her to the limit to earn the right to sit on the redhead’s face. Madison tried to clear her mind of everything but the mission and roll with it, but then Farah took out a new toy, a thick dildo, and pushed it deep inside the redhead’s drenched pussy. Farah added the wand again, and Madison came apart all over again.

It was going to be a long afternoon.

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Nyx was hot and sweaty. It was packed on a Saturday night. The tiny, gauzy white dress Müller gave her would have been a relief if she were more comfortable being essentially naked in public. She was used to strutting around the *Rheingold* with nothing on by now, but she still hadn't quite adapted to the casual European attitude toward nudity.

Most of the women around her in the Mykonos club were just as naked as she was, but that still didn't make her feel great about it. Madison had stopped going to Mass the moment her mother allowed it, but she hadn't totally shaken those old mores.

Müller had enough juice to get them into the small, roped-off VIP section, but even there, it felt like everyone was on top of them. And Yuki and Farah kept dragging her out to dance anyway. The only thing that made Madison feel better was that Tariq looked supremely uncomfortable in the nightclub.

An afternoon of being strapped to that bed on the *Rheingold* and sexually tormented had left her exhausted. The last thing she felt like doing was getting out and bouncing up and down with a crowd of sweaty, sticky Europeans. Madison would have been content to lie on the upper deck of the yacht and stare up at the stars. She would even have blown Müller for the privilege. But she had work to do, and not *his* work.

Madison contacted her team once they were ashore. The chaos at Nyx was good for something. A dark-haired officer she only knew as Jen found her in the ladies' room and they exchanged iPods without an issue. But she'd grabbed the officer's arm before she could go.

"Tariq al-Kharabati is with us. I think we should grab him tonight."

"What is the urgency? We can track him when he leaves the yacht. I don't know that just snatching him up is worth the trouble it would bring. He's the king's brother."

Jen punctuated her criticism with an equally critical look at Madison's outfit. It was little more than scraps of thin-spun linen held together by strings. She wore a G-string, but a bra was impossible. Spiked heels completed the gold-digger, party girl look. The other officer wore a little black dress to fit in, but it didn't show nearly as much as Madison's outfit. She felt like saying, *I didn't choose this. It's the job*. She was sure Jen had compromised herself in other ways.

"You're going to find a huge money transfer by Müller on behalf of the Kharabatis. He's been unusually tense. I think a major attack could be imminent. We need to grab Tariq and find out what he knows. I don't want a tragedy to happen again because we ignored intel."

"Listen, you have your job here, and it's not to make operational decisions."

The CIA officers had a staring match while other passing women jostled them. Madison took satisfaction that Jen's eyes kept flicking to her tits, which tried to escape from the dress every time she moved. She was more locked in than the serious officer.

"Fine. I'll pass it along. We'll find some way to signal you if we're going to make a move. Just sit tight until then."

"Is there a problem, Eileen? Is this bitch bothering you?"

It was Yuki, coming in hot. The tension between Madison and Jen was obvious. Yuki cursed in Japanese and rolled her shoulders. She was ready to

throw down. Müller's women had been doing shots since they arrived, loosening the already uninhibited woman.

"No, no problem. Just a misunderstanding," Madison said.

"She thought I was trying to steal her iPod. But I have my own." Jen held up the music player she'd taken from the redhead. "Just a misunderstanding. Have fun, ladies."

"*Bitch*," Yuki muttered in her native language.

As she walked away, Jen threw her own epithet over her shoulder, replying in Japanese. "*Cunt*."

Yuki started at the woman, but Madison grabbed her arm. "Hey, let it go. We don't want the boss's guys to have to pull us out of a scrape, do we?"

Yuki made a face, shook her arm free, and huffed, "Fine."

Madison laughed and added, "And maybe lay off the coke before your heart explodes."

MADISON SMILED and tried to look like she was a carefree party girl, but she spent the entire time looking around the club for a signal from the CIA team. Jen was nowhere to be seen. They had to grab Tariq, didn't they? She didn't want to make it about her, but she was the officer on the ground, and they should trust her judgment.

Müller's hand inside her dress was a pleasant distraction. She was taking a break from the dance floor and sat on his lap. She tried to tell herself that it was because it was the role she was playing—and there was nowhere else to sit—but she liked feeling his warmth against her.

He rolled her tender nipple just the way she liked it—a technique he'd learned from watching Farah tease her. It wasn't even sexual. His touch just

felt good, and it grounded Madison while her nerves frayed over the operation.

Well. It wasn't entirely sexual. Any attention to her breasts always made her wet, and she was soaked down below, but she still didn't see it as inherently sexual because Müller was playing with her breast in the same way he'd use a stress ball. He wasn't trying to progress things and fuck Madison right there in the club. Although if he kept going, anything was possible. She was beginning to suspect that she didn't know what she could do in the bedroom. Her limits certainly were not what she'd thought they were.

All things considered, Müller wasn't a horrible man. He didn't mistreat the women he hired. He was good to his staff. Even when one of the girls was strapped to the bed in the playroom, it was all about pleasure. Müller had no desire to hurt his women. His only flaw was moving money for the world's worst people and profiting off their crimes. Yeah, *that* was a problem.

Nyx kept swinging into the wee hours, but Müller was well past his party all night days, and he told the crew that he was ready to go back to the *Rheingold* sometime after two. Tariq would be a guest on the yacht that night, and it was strongly implied that he could continue partying with the girls as long as he liked. Madison didn't like the way Tariq looked at her.

The club was down a steep set of stairs off a narrow alley. The group was buffered by Felix, Tobias, and Tilo. Small groups and couples filtered down the alley as they reached the top of the steps. It was late, but Mykonos never stopped. When they turned toward the mouth of the alley, a broad man stepped out of the shadow of a doorway. He wore a balaclava and pointed a Glock at the group.

Felix offered his hands with a smile and in German said, "These are not people you want to rob, friend. Move aside, and we'll forget this

happened.” When the stranger didn’t answer, he repeated it in thickly accented English.

“Step aside, and you won’t get hurt. Just let us take what we’re here for,” the stranger replied with an American accent. “I don’t give a shit about your boss. Not tonight, anyway.”

Madison was annoyed that no one bothered to tell her this was going down, but she readied herself for action. She’d let Farah and Yuki think she was keeping up with their drinking but had stayed mostly sober. She was just behind Tariq in the group—a perfect position to make a move.

“Us, friend?” Felix said, maintaining his smile. He turned so that the slight movement of his hand toward his hip was covered by Yuki’s body. “I only see one of you.”

“What’s going on?” Madison asked frightfully, clinging to Tariq’s arm.

“Nothing to be concerned about. My men will handle this. No one in their right mind fucks with me,” Müller reassured her. His hand was snaking around to the back of his waistband. He was not a man who relied entirely on his security.

Two more people stepped out of the shadows at their rear. They were also armed.

“We’re here for al-Kharabati. Don’t make this bloody if it doesn’t have to be,” the lead man warned.

Müller didn’t wait for his security detail; he swung a small Walther pistol free of his jacket and fired at the man in front of them. The assailant grunted when the round clipped his arm. He brought up his own weapon.

“No!” Madison shouted, releasing Tariq to grab Farah and Yuki and pull them to the side.

The CIA rendition team was armed, but she couldn’t believe they’d actually fire into the group. She was standing in the middle of it for one thing, but perhaps more importantly, they couldn’t risk killing Tariq. The lead man did fire, taking Felix in the shoulder.

Asshole, Madison thought. It was a reflex from being shot at, but he was trained better than that.

The two at the rear of the group closed quickly, holstering their weapons and flicking out tactical batons. Their training held, and they didn't shoot. Tilo got off a shot, but the alley was dark and narrow, and it harmlessly ricocheted off a stone wall. The hard tip of a baton came crashing down on his wrist, and the pistol tumbled to the stone at their feet, spinning off into the shadows.

Chaos quickly followed. Tobias was smart enough to know that his Sig Sauer was useless in such close quarters and flicked out a knife. He grappled with one of the rendition team, driving the man back against a wall. The CIA officer grunted when the blade swept across his abdomen. Tilo engaged the other attacker, but his left hand was still numb from the blow of the baton.

Madison was torn. The rendition team may have kept her in the dark because they wanted her to play her role and stay undercover. *A heads-up still would have been nice*, she thought. But staying passively on the sidelines was not her style; she was desperate to jump into the fray.

The man engaged with Tilo had the edge because of the German's useless hand. The CIA officer blocked punches from Tilo's good hand and delivered a series of body blows that sent the bodyguard slumping to the cobblestones. The agent drew back to deliver a baton blow that would render Tilo unconscious, if not fracture his skull.

Müller leapt forward, coming to his man's aid. He grabbed the tactical baton and yanked it back while delivering kidney punches to the officer. The money man was able to wrest the baton free and turn it on the masked CIA officer. He rained down a series of blows that drove the other man to his knees.

"*Fuck*," Madison murmured. She could not sit back and watch Müller beat a fellow CIA officer to death. She broke away from Tariq and the other

girls and rushed at the German.

“What is this?” Müller exclaimed, ripping the mask off the man he was beating. “Mal? What is going on? What are you doing here?”

“Hey, guv. Quite a spot of trouble, innit?” Mal replied in his thick, Cockney chimney sweep accent. Madison wondered why he bothered with it now.

The mental math took a moment, and he turned just in time to be knocked against the wall by Madison. Her cover was blown anyway. Obviously, Mal was not some sleazy Londoner dealing desperate women to wealthy men.

Müller swung the baton at Madison, and pain shot up her arm when she blocked it. He would have shattered the bone if he’d had a full swing behind it. She ignored it and delivered a sharp right to the German’s face. She punched him two...three times in rapid succession and felt cartilage snap under her fist. Blood flowed from his ruined nose.

Growling with rage, Müller dove forward, driving Madison to the cobblestones, where he locked his fingers in her flaming hair and tried to slam her head back against the alley’s surface. The first blow blinded her with white light. She vaguely heard Mal call out, “Maddy!”

Müller yanked her head up again to slam it back and scatter her brains on the cobblestones when Mal hooked his arm and dragged him backward.

“Get the fuck off her,” Mal snarled.

“Fuck you! I’ll get the truth of this, and then I’ll feed your balls to the sharks,” Müller promised in German.

The men wrestled and rolled in the alleyway. The fight between the Germans and the rendition team was still very much up in the air. The officer battling Tobias kept his arms in a defensive posture while the German slashed at him with ruthless efficiency. The man fighting Felix fared better, spinning the bodyguard away from him, creating enough room to draw his weapon again.

“My family’s been kicking Kraut ass—” Mal paused to headbutt Müller, “—for three damn generations. We’re not about to stop now.”

Müller fell away from Mal, who scrambled to a couch, ready to finish the German. But Müller’s hand landed on one of the pistols that had fallen to the ground, and he trained it on his foe.

“Limey bastard,” Müller grinned.

“Just go down, you motherfucker,” Madison cried.

She slammed one of her shoes down, embedding the spiked, chrome heel in Müller’s neck. Bright, arterial blood sprayed out, soaking her gauzy white dress. He looked up at her with mild surprise as the Glock tumbled from his fingers.

“Jesus Christ, Maddy,” Mal said, watching the life flow out of Müller’s neck.

“Is that how you say thank you, Kane?” she replied.

“I had him. Pretty sure I’m the one who saved you from getting your brains bashed out,” Mal answered, losing the terrible Cockney accent. Kane had finally dropped the mask of his cover.

“After I kept him from beating you with your own baton.”

Madison crawled across the German and snagged the Glock. The weapon barked three times, echoing loudly in the alley, and dropped Tobias. One more shot followed. It was the other CIA officer killing Felix.

Kane went to the bleeding officer who’d been fighting Tobias. Madison climbed to her feet, still woozy from her head injury, but stable enough. She trained the Glock on Tariq with a two-handed grip.

“Move away from them, Tariq. Put your hands on your head,” she instructed.

Tariq grabbed Yuki, but he froze when Madison put a round in the wall beside his head.

“I swear to God, I’ll fucking end you. Step out, Tariq,” Madison warned.

Given that she was seeing double, Madison thought it was a minor miracle that she didn't take his head off or shoot Yuki. Tariq finally did as he was told, stepping into the alley. Police sirens screamed in the distance.

"American bitch," Tariq spat.

"That's enough of that," the lead officer said, wrenching Tariq's hands behind his back and securing them with a thick zip tie. "Keep your mouth shut until I start asking questions."

"Eileen, what is going on?" Farah asked.

"I'm sorry," Madison replied.

"Are you with them?"

Tilo stared up at everyone with a dazed expression. When he tried to rise to his feet, Kane kicked him in the face, knocking him back down.

"We need to move. We don't want to explain this to the Greek authorities," Kane said, half-carrying the wounded CIA officer. "Come on, Maddy. Let's move. You can't stay here."

A black van screeched to a halt at the mouth of the alley. Jen was behind the wheel. The masked agent dragged Tariq, and Kane carried his fellow officer. Madison followed, covering their rear, but Müller and his men wouldn't be bothering them. She felt bad for leaving Farah and Yuki in the alley, but she couldn't stay. They were resourceful girls. They'd figure something out.

"My brother is the king! You won't get away with this!" Tariq protested as he was unceremoniously shoved into the back of the van. He landed hard on the metal floor.

"Yeah, shut the fuck up," the masked officer replied.

The rest of the rendition team piled into the van, and Madison pulled the door closed with a loud bang. Jen floored it, and they disappeared into the night as the Greek police rounded the corner, sirens blazing.

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Present Day **Philadelphia**

“DID you know that Anatoly Reznikov is still alive?”

Madison leaned on the dining room table with both hands and glared at her handler. They were in the Rittenhouse Square condo the Agency had rented to serve as the Richardsons’ residence.

“I didn’t even know who Anatoly Reznikov was before tonight,” Cassandra replied.

That wasn’t strictly true. The thorough woman had read Madison’s file front to back when Operation Scarlet Phantom began, as she had for all her team members. Madison’s final field mission involving Reznikov and Kane featured prominently in her file.

“Did the Agency know?” Madison didn’t hold back any of her redheaded temper.

“I can’t answer that. I don’t know anything about Anatoly Reznikov or his son.” Cassandra stepped back from the table like she was afraid Madison was going to come across it.

“We barely walked away from that mission. I think we have the right to know,” Kane added. He stood back from the table, leaning against the wall with his hands in his pockets.

The other two members of the team, Dentiger and Manny, watched from the living room. They were happy to stay out of the drama.

“How can he be alive?” Madison asked, incredulous. “I shot him in the head.”

Madison still vividly remembered the moment, although sixteen years of living the normal life of a suburban mom made it feel more like something she’d seen in a movie rather than something she’d done. It was the last time she’d killed a man.

Reznikov would have killed her if she hadn’t used the body of one of his guards to shield herself. He’d already shot Kane. Madison put three bullets into the Russian—two in his chest and one in his head. *No one walks away from that*, she thought.

Cassandra was annoyed with her officers. They were supposed to be professionals. They were also at least a decade older than she was. Madison and Kane should have been able to keep their cool.

“I don’t know anything. I’m telling you I will try to find out, but it’s 4:00 a.m. I don’t think I can learn anything tonight. Everyone should get some rest, and we’ll look at this with fresh eyes tomorrow. We’re going to need our rest because tomorrow is going to be a long one now that we have to go back to Nox Venari.”

“We can’t go back there,” Madison replied.

“Not until we know more,” Kane agreed. “How do we know this isn’t some kind of setup?”

“Now you’re being paranoid,” Dentiger chimed in from the living room. “How could it possibly be a setup? Assuming the opposition knows about Scarlet Phantom at all, the Agency could have sent anyone on this mission.

They couldn't have known it would be you two. Besides, they don't know. You're David and Melissa Richardson to them."

"I don't believe in coincidences after twenty-five years in the field," Kane replied, annoyed that the younger man was butting in.

"I think too much time out there has you scared of your own shadow."

Kane pushed off the wall and started toward Dentiger, who sprang off the couch. The men had been butting heads since the start of the mission, and Kane was tired of it. The Black man was younger and larger than he was, but that didn't deter Kane. Size didn't matter when it came to taking someone down. Madison had dropped him on the training course.

"Guys," Manny said, shrinking back on the loveseat. He didn't want any part of a fight between the alpha males.

"Why don't you find out how scared I am?" Kane asked. He was close enough to pluck the toothpick out of Dentiger's mouth.

"I don't pick on senior citizens. I'll give you the first shot...if you can land it," Dentiger sneered.

Kane steeled himself and drew back to strike.

"Damien," Madison softly said. "Don't. Don't make it worse."

"Listen to your wife. Go sit down," Dentiger taunted.

"Shut your mouth, or I'll drop you myself," Madison said, adding, "Again."

Dentiger smirked. "Anytime you want to tangle again, *Maddy*, I'm your man. I'll pin you better than the old man did tonight."

Kane swung on him, but Madison was faster. She hooked his arm and pulled him away from their colleague. He struggled against her, but she was deceptively strong for a soccer mom. Maybe she had been on a desk at Langley for the last sixteen years, but she was still in peak shape.

"Let it go, Damien. He's an asshole. Just let it lie," she said, turning him and pressing against his chest, putting her body between the men.

Being against Kane's hard, warm body reminded her of that pinning Dentiger had been talking about. They didn't have a choice in the moment, but Madison's plan to limit her physical contact to Prince Zaydan—and only then when absolutely necessary—had been a failure so far.

Madison had to fuck Kane in a command performance for Zaydan. They could hardly deny him without arousing suspicion. They were supposed to be a pair of married empty nesters looking to spice up their sex life. It was something else she hadn't done in sixteen years—just like killing a man. If their mission came to it, she had to hope the latter came as easy as falling into bed with Kane had been. It had felt like no time had passed between them at all.

"Goddamn it! Why can't you people behave?" Cassandra rolled her eyes. "Do you have it out of your system now? Dentiger is right. Sergei Reznikov's involvement changes nothing. We proceed as planned."

"I don't think you heard me. I can't go back in there," Madison stressed.

"That mission from the past involved his father, not Sergei. I don't see the problem."

"I met him back then. Sergei. It was only a few times, but I met him. His mother would drop him off at the dacha to spend time with his father. Anatoly had no interest and kept going like nothing had changed. But I spent time with Sergei. Anatoly acted like I was a babysitter on top of everything else."

Madison hadn't thought about her time at Reznikov's dacha in years, but she remembered the time she spent with Sergei. It was only over a couple of weekends in the months she was undercover, but they had been rare moments when she had been able to relax; they stuck out in her mind. She still had to play the role of Milica Jovanovic, former aspiring ballet dancer turned desperate shot girl, but it was calmer than being around Reznikov's security guys.

Sergei was a sweet kid with an easy laugh. She knew he was just thrilled that someone was paying attention to him. That it was a pretty redhead giving the attention didn't hurt. His crush had developed quickly. He was a teenager, and he'd seemed to understand who his father was, so given the way Reznikov liked her to dress, Sergei surely knew why Madison was there. Although he never made a move, he may have thought he had a shot because of what Milica was.

"Is he really going to remember a woman he spent a little time with over a decade ago? I'm sure you were just one in a long line of women his father kept around," Cassandra said.

"And, no offense, but I doubt you look exactly the same as you did when you went undercover as his father's whore," Dentiger added. "You didn't fuck him too, did you?"

This time, it was Kane who had to hold Madison back. He whispered, "Remember, he's just an asshole, right? He's pissed that he's stuck outside while we're doing the real work. Let him be jealous."

"That is enough, Tay." The steel in Cassandra's tone was clear. He'd crossed a line, and she was finished with it. "Don't push me any further."

Dentiger held up both hands in surrender. "Okay. I hear you. Loud and clear." He retreated to the living room and sat again.

"Tay may be a pig, but he's right again," Cassandra continued. "How likely is it that Sergei would recognize you after all this time, in an entirely different context? He might think there's something familiar about you, but I don't believe he'll connect the dots."

"Maybe I was just one of many *whores*," Madison paused to glare at Dentiger when she said it. "But I'm the whore who killed his father. Sorry, *shot* his father. I think this is a huge risk."

"I appreciate that," Cassandra replied. "But given the stakes with Null:Echo, I think it's acceptable, and it's my call to make."

"Easy to make that call when you're sitting in the van," Kane said.

“Nevertheless, it’s still my decision. Zaydan wants to see you, so you’ll see him. The Russians are here, which means we can’t waste any time.”

Madison stared at Cassandra and saw that the younger woman was not going to break. She admired Cassandra’s strength and drive. Perhaps if she’d had it at that age, she would be sitting in Jennifer Bristow’s chair right now instead of hoping a Russian gangster didn’t realize she was the woman who shot his father in the head.

All the fight drained out of Madison at once like a pressure valve releasing. It had been a long night filled with life-changing events. “Fine. I’m going to bed. We’ll deal with this tomorrow—or later today, I guess.”

“Good work tonight, Madison. I know it wasn’t easy,” Cassandra said.

Madison ignored her and went up to the master bedroom, praying Kane didn’t follow her.

KANE CAUGHT Cassandra before the team dispersed for the night. She and Dentiger would be going to a hotel. Kane and Manny had the other two bedrooms in the condo.

“She’s right, you know. Sending us, particularly her, back in there is a bad idea,” he told her. They were alone in the kitchen. Manny had gone up to his room, and Dentiger was taking gear out to the SUV.

“Honestly, Kane, that’s immaterial,” Cassandra answered. She almost looked apologetic. “The two of you are in there now, and you know how dangerous Null:Echo could be if it gets into the wrong hands. We have to roll the dice. I’m sorry.”

“Says the woman who isn’t going out there.”

“That’s not fair. If I were in your position, I’d do what I had to do for the success of the mission.”

“But you’re not. Have you ever been? Do you have any hard field experience?”

“I’ve been out there,” Cassandra replied, choosing her words carefully.

Her hesitation told Kane everything he needed to know. For most of his career, it had been people behind desks with little to no practical experience making the calls that put his life on the line.

“And have you ever done the kind of work Maddy’s doing?” Kane asked. His handler made a face before shaking her head. “That’s what I thought.”

“I would do whatever I had to. Trust me. The mission always comes first. I know you two understand that.”

“We understand it. Better than you ever will.”

They were interrupted by Dentiger’s return. “Hey, are you ready to head to the hotel? I’m exhausted. I’m going to have to sleep on the couch if we don’t get moving.”

“Yeah, we’re done here. You two might as well head out,” Kane replied for Cassandra.

“We can talk about this tomorrow, Kane,” she said.

“I think we’ve said enough.”

Dentiger looked between the two of them like he wanted to get involved. Kane wished he would. He’d taken enough of the man’s shit. He was ready to grab a knife from the block on the counter and teach the younger man a lesson. Kane didn’t care how big he was.

“Let’s go,” Cassandra said, putting a hand on Dentiger’s chest.

Kane watched them leave and thought, *there’s something going on there*. He didn’t think Cassandra was one who’d fuck someone on her team, but you never knew. Strange things happened in the pressure cooker of field ops.

On the way to his room, Kane lingered at Madison’s door. The temptation to knock was overwhelming. All he wanted to do was go in and

slip into her bed, but he knew that was the worst possible thing he could do. She was at her wits' end.

The tuxedo shirt was thrown carelessly onto the floor of his bedroom. The jacket had landed on the couch downstairs the moment they'd gotten back to Philadelphia. Kane sighed and looked at himself in the long mirror on the closet door. He wasn't a man who usually paused for self-reflection, but if there was ever a night for it, this was it.

Madison looked incredible naked. She felt even better when he touched her. Maybe her hips and ass were a little rounder, her breasts a little softer, but he swore it was like those sixteen years hadn't passed at all. If anything, she was even sexier than before. The sex had been scorching.

Have I held up as well? It was not a question Kane had ever considered. Sure, he was older, but he was in good shape—especially compared to other men his age. He had to be in better shape than Charles Sinclair. The man was a lobbyist.

His dark hair had shot through with gray since the last time he and Madison had been together. Even his chest hair was starting to turn. But at least his chest itself hadn't gone to flab. He wasn't cut like he'd been a decade ago, but he was fifty. He was still just as powerful under that layer of softness.

Kane touched the bullet hole in his side from that Munich mission. It was right under a long, jagged scar from a knife in Jakarta. Madison had stitched that one. She hadn't done a bad job. She'd told him her mother taught her how to sew at a young age because so many of her clothes were secondhand and had to be altered.

Madison had been there for most of his scars, but there were a few new ones from the intervening sixteen years. *Did she look at me and see her old lover?* he wondered. *Or did she just see all the wear and tear?* Madison seemed as hungry for him as she ever had. That was a good sign. Kane laughed at himself.

She loves her husband. She's been very clear on that.

Kane dropped onto the bed and pulled out the bottle of Old Hickory he'd stashed in the nightstand drawer. After a long pull on the bottle, he thought, *she didn't fuck me like she loves her husband.*

He knew that wasn't fair—emotions were more complicated than that—but he didn't feel like being fair. Not at four in the morning. He tipped the bottle back to his mouth and drank until he needed to come up for air. It barely dulled the pain. For once, it wasn't the ache of a thousand injuries piled up over twenty-eight years in the field he was trying to stifle. The pain was deep in his soul.

"Fuck," he muttered to himself.

Sixteen years. Madison wasn't the same woman. Kane understood that, but when he looked at her, he didn't see the suburban mom. He saw his Maddy. And goddamn it, he still wanted her. She'd just left him that day in London. There'd been no closure at all.

Kane just kept moving along as if nothing had happened. Once he was healed up from Moscow, he went on to the next mission, found someone new to fuck. A lot of someones.

And Madison built a new life with Charles Sinclair. They had a daughter right away, Penny. A few years later, a son, Charles, Jr. He'd never thought kids were in the cards for him, but if he and Madison had stayed together, would there have been a Damien, Jr.? Would some version of Penny have been theirs?

Penny was sixteen years old. It was easy enough to imagine them starting that life instead of Madison and Charles Sinclair. Too easy.

Kane had done the math and wondered. He didn't want to think Madison was the sort of woman who'd do that, keep his child from him, but how well does anyone really know anyone else? Part of him could understand if she'd done it. He knew her past. He knew how important

security was to Madison. She would do anything to give that to her child. But if she had, part of him would never forgive her.

Swilling more Old Hickory, Kane made himself forget. Too many of his nights had ended this way since the Agency had reunited him and Madison. There were some things he just couldn't bear to think about.

six

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Cassandra tossed her leather jacket onto the desk chair when she walked into the hotel room. Slipping the paddle holster out of her jeans, she laid the secured Glock 19 on the desk with a sigh. It literally felt like she was laying down her burden.

Being away from her team was a relief. She was tired of being argued with. Still, she questioned her decision. She'd always hated her tendency to second-guess herself. It was something she'd worked hard to eliminate from her personality. She bent over and took a bottle of water out of the minifridge. She didn't turn to drink like many people did when she was stressed, but she was thirsty.

"Do you think I'm right about this? Sending Madison and Kane back into Nox Venari?" she asked, adding, "And get your hand off my ass."

Dentiger chuckled. "It's a damn inviting target, Cassie. You can't blame me."

She removed his hand, but not before giving her butt a little shake. Cassandra would never admit it, but she was a little jealous of all the attention Madison was receiving. She wasn't about that at all, but it was nice to be appreciated.

"Don't call me Cassie. I hate that. Remember, I'm your team leader, Tay. Answer me."

“Yeah, of course you’re right. We don’t have time to come up with a Plan B. They both know that, too. Is there a chance it could go bad? Sure. That’s part of the job. If they weren’t fossils, they’d just roll with it. But Kane’s a fucking burnout, and Maddy’s a goddamn soccer mom. She should have stayed behind a desk. I don’t know what Bristow was thinking putting this operation in her hands. The Agency needs to move the mandatory retirement age down. At least, to retire people from the field.”

Cassandra shook her head at him. Dentiger was very good at his job, but he was stubborn and saw the world in black and white, which could be a liability in the field. She suspected that Kane had once been very much like Dentiger.

“They’re only in their forties. Kane might be a little older,” she replied.

“He looks old as shit. Looks like he could be my gramps—if he wasn’t so pale.” Dentiger laughed at his own quip.

“Field ops age you, Tay. And he’s seen a lot. There’s a lot of wear and tear on him, but I’ve seen his file. Kane is one of the best officers the Agency has ever had. Don’t underestimate him.” Dentiger snorted, and she went on. “We’ll be their age someday too, you know.”

“We’ll be running this place when we’re their age.”

Dentiger came closer and pulled Cassandra against him by her hips. She pushed at his chest playfully.

“I wonder why Kane’s stayed in the field all this time. He could at least be a station chief by now.”

“Why are you still talking about that old fuck? Don’t tell me you’ve got a thing for him.”

“He might be old enough to be my dad,” she replied, laughing warmly. “I don’t have daddy issues.”

Even without daddy issues, however, Cassandra couldn’t help but notice that Damien Kane was a handsome man. He had a lot of wear and tear, but

his cool confidence and gravitas were sexy. She understood why Madison fell for him when they were younger.

“I do not look at him the way you look at Madison,” she countered, smiling. Cassandra saw the way all the men on their team looked at the redhead. It didn’t bother her—not really. After all, Dentiger was there with her, right?

“How do I look at her?” he asked, playfully trying to kiss her, while she teasingly evaded his lips.

“Like you’d love to pin her, and not in the way you tried on the training course at The Farm.” She laughed and him to land a peck on her lips.

“She’s hardly my type.” The denial wasn’t remotely convincing. “Like you said about Kane, she’s probably old enough to be my mother.” He landed another kiss, and his hips moved suggestively against her.

Cassandra ran her hand over his smooth, shaved head. His dark skin was smooth. Flawless. He might have been the most handsome man she’d ever seen. It bothered her because it was the reason she’d fallen into bed with him when she knew she shouldn’t. She couldn’t get close to those lips without wanting to kiss them. Cassandra was only playing hard to get so she didn’t look too easy.

“Madison is *not* old enough to be your mom. And let’s be real, Tay. She doesn’t look it either. I’d kill to have her genes—”

“Asian women don’t age, baby,” he interrupted, landing another kiss.

“Until we age all at once.”

Cassandra smiled and allowed a long, lingering kiss, thinking that Dentiger would not be around to see that happen. She didn’t kid herself. She understood exactly what this was with him. They wouldn’t be babysitting grandchildren together one day. She peeled her lips from his.

“It’s okay if you have a MILF thing, Tay. It’s pretty common, and I get that she’s hot—if you like redheads.”

His eyebrows went up. “You think she’s hot?”

“Don’t be getting any crazy threesome fantasies. I’m not that kind of a girl.” She laughed at him.

Dentiger grinned. “Why don’t you show me exactly what kind of girl you are?”

Cassandra guided him toward the bed while they kissed, tongues battling for supremacy. She wrestled the tight olive green t-shirt off his body while he pulled her white ribbed tank top from her jeans. Her fingers traced the ripples of his muscles across his granite chest.

Every time she saw him shirtless, she couldn’t quite believe she got to fool around with a man built like that. Dentiger was what she used to dream about when she touched herself and thought about who’d take her virginity.

Wrenching his wide belt open, she had to pause at the fun part because he insisted on pulling her tank top over her head. Cassandra only wore a plain t-shirt bra under it, but he looked at her like she was a Victoria’s Secret model. That was one of the reasons she always melted for him. The man knew how to make a woman feel desired. His big, dark hands covered her breasts, and she reached back to unhook the bra. She wanted to feel his skin on hers.

“Love the way you fucking shiver when I do that, baby,” he marveled, rolling her thick, dark nipples with his thumbs.

“It’s the way you touch me...” she moaned between kisses. “I can’t help it.”

It was mostly true. Her nipples were unbelievably sensitive, no matter who touched them. They were so thick and constantly stood at attention, making them difficult to hide. Thick nipples on perky little boobs. She’d had to work to get over being embarrassed by them.

In a hurry, Cassandra tried to push his black tactical pants down with one hand while she reached into his boxer briefs with the other. Dentiger was hot and thick in her grasp. He froze when she pumped his shaft, like it short-circuited his brain. He loved the way playing with her nipples drove

her crazy—but she loved the way grabbing his cock seemed to blow his mind.

“Fuck...yeah...Cass...” he moaned.

She reluctantly released him. She needed more than one hand to get his pants off. She grabbed the waist and yanked hard, kneeling to get them lower. His thick, dark meat nearly slapped her in the face. Dentiger was *that* big. She hit a roadblock when she reached his combat boots.

Cassandra gave his cock a quick, intense suck—stretching her lips around his head—and told him, “Get your pants off and get on the bed.”

Dentiger laughed. “Always have to remind me who the boss is, don’t you?”

She smirked with a twinkle in her eye. “Respect the chain of command, Tay.”

Cassandra kicked off her own boots—cuter, but just as practical—and rolled her jeans over her narrow hips. Dentiger watched the way she moved—the wiggle of her hips, the jiggle of her tits—while he threw off his boots and pants with alacrity. He was on the bed when she was ready for him.

She needed a moment to admire him. He was in peak physical condition. Except for an obvious bullet scar near his collarbone and another long, jagged scar on his calf, he was perfect. Nerdy Cassandra Gale, whose biggest social commitment in high school was the Mock UN, never thought she’d get to climb on top of a man who looked like Tayshawn Dentiger. His ebony body was a work of art in the soft light from the desk lamp. That thick cock stood up and pulsed. For her. And god, she wanted it.

Cassandra crawled onto the bed, and Dentiger smiled. This wasn’t their first rodeo. He knew what came next, and he loved it. She wondered about that. Did it mean the big, muscular man was secretly submissive? The question didn’t matter enough to slow her down as she straddled his head, but she knew not every guy was into something like that.

“I love your fucking scent, baby,” he cooed from her between her legs. His deep voice made her thighs vibrate. His big hands gripped her tight ass, and he pulled her close enough to kiss. “I love how you taste even better.”

“Show me, Tay,” she gasped, feeling his tongue tracing up her slit.

She gripped the headboard and rolled her hips, grinding her pussy at the rough man’s face. His stubble, grown in over a long day, irritated her thighs, but she didn’t even care. The way his tongue explored her, the way he softly kissed her most intimate place, overwhelmed anything else she felt. The intense waves of pleasure washed through her within seconds of making contact. He knew exactly what he was doing to her.

It was nearly impossible to believe that, back in college, she’d been too self-conscious to let a guy kiss her there at all. She denied her first two boyfriends the pleasure because she was always worried they were doing it out of obligation or they’d get down there and it would turn them off. Cassandra did not come from a sex positive household.

She kept her mouth locked closed, but a warm hum of pleasure still escaped her lips. Closing her eyes, she hung her head and allowed herself to just feel. She blocked out everything but the feeling of his tongue dancing on her clit. The soft sounds of how wet he made her floated up to her ears.

“Ohhh god...Tay...”

Cassandra threw her head back and moaned it when he began sucking on her clit, whipping her long, silky black hair. She trembled and tried to ease back when it got too intense, but his tight grip on her ass trapped her there, forcing her to accept the pleasure. She could be like that sometimes, fighting the climax.

Using the headboard for leverage, she pulled her pussy away from his mouth and utilized her CIA training to flip around without kneeing Dentiger in the head or crushing her weight down on his chest. Her new position kept her pussy in his face, but now his thick cock was right in hers. She grabbed it at the base.

“Cass, baby, what are you... Oh fuck, yeah, baby...”

Dentiger had no idea what had gotten into Cassandra, but he wasn't going to complain. She closed her lips over the head of his cock and started sucking like a shop vac. Sure, she loved sitting on his face. Unless she was a little drunk and already turned on, she started it that way almost every time. But she'd never flipped around on him into a 69 position. He wondered if the things they'd witnessed on the camera feed from Nox Venari were in her head. They were certainly in his.

Cassandra bobbed aggressively on his cock. He'd been with more than a few women, but he'd never been with anyone who gave head like this one.

She was like a demon when she got his cock into her mouth. He swore she was on a mission to suck the cum out of his balls as quickly as possible, and with a mouth like that, she could get it done. She didn't finesse it. Other women tried to impress with a lot of tongue or sexy kisses, even eye contact to say, *I love this*, but that wasn't Cassandra's game. She pistoned her mouth up and down and jerked what she couldn't fit past her lips, and sucked his dick with a single-mindedness he admired.

Dentiger tried to tell her she didn't have to do that if she didn't want to, but Cassandra always swore she did. And damn, he would never turn down a blowjob. Memories of Madison blowing Prince Zaydan popped into his head. That woman didn't suck dick like it was a chore, like it was her job—which he supposed it was.

Madison had swallowed that terrorist like she loved it. She claimed to hate it, always reminded everyone that she didn't want to betray her husband waiting back at home in DC, but that wasn't how it looked to Dentiger. That was a woman who loved getting a cock in her mouth.

Cassandra faltered when he resumed sucking on her clit. He was pleased to see a crack in her facade and sucked harder. She froze and moaned into his cock when she rubbed her labia with his thumbs while sucking. Dentiger was determined to make her come. If they weren't going

to fuck tonight, and it was just going to be this, he was damn well determined to make sure she came first. He rarely got to make her come like that anyway.

Cassandra always jumped off his face before she reached climax. When he asked why, she told him it was because that wasn't what she needed from him, but to be ready for what she needed, she wanted his mouth first. Dentiger knew that wasn't true tonight. She was already soaked when she sat on his face.

Dentiger began pumping his hips up from the bed. If she wasn't going to do the job, he'd fuck her mouth. It was that simple. He needed to take back some control anyway. She made strange noises like she was choking on him, but he realized those were deep, uncontrolled moans. Cassandra wasn't in control for once. He was seeing a new side of her.

He took it as confirmation that she was just as affected by Nox Venari as he'd been—as they'd all been. They were professionals, but they were human. Dentiger was sure that Manny was jerking it back at that condo the second he was alone. He was also confident that Kane had slipped into Madison's room and was giving her a second helping. Knowing that the old man's cock was probably in the redhead's mouth just like his was in their boss's was pretty hot.

Cassandra tore her mouth from Dentiger with a keening cry. He slapped against her cheek, but she didn't care. Her orgasm was so sharp that it almost hurt. She came that way sometimes, so intensely she didn't even know if she liked it. It wasn't his fault. He was just so good at going down on her—or up, in her case.

"Fuck, baby, that's hot," he said, when she pried out of his grip once again.

Her orgasm had left her shaky, so she wasn't quite as graceful this time when she flipped around, squatting right over Dentiger's thick, hot meat. The head teased her lips, making her tremble. He was always such a tight

fit, but this time she was more than ready. She sank onto him with a satisfied moan. God, she loved the stretch—the feeling of him breaking her open. She loved the way it hurt, just a little bit.

“Fuuuuck...yesss...baby...” Dentiger moaned.

It was drawn out, like the way she sank onto him. He had to exercise all his control when she first settled onto his cock to avoid being a two-pump chump and filling her the second she was seated on him. He’d never been inside a tighter woman. He didn’t know how it didn’t hurt her, but Cassandra loved it. She fucked just as intensely as she sucked cock.

Dentiger held both of her hands, helping her balance on the balls of her feet. She rolled her hips, gyrating her pussy on his cock like she was stirring herself with it. Her eyes were closed, and her mouth hung open. It looked to him like she was trying to get used to his intrusion. Cassandra was, but only because she wanted to savor the deep throb he brought to her core.

“Come on, baby, fuck me... You know I can’t wait,” he moaned.

She smiled, eyes still closed. “You’ll wait until I’m ready. *Mmm...*”

She rippled around him, and he almost lost it.

“And what’s to stop me from throwing you down and fucking the shit out of you, baby?” he countered. She worked those muscles again. *“Ahhh shit, Cass... Please, baby...”*

Cassandra laughed. She was feeling playful. “Respect the chain of command, Tay.”

Deciding that he’d had enough—that she’d savored the stretch long enough—she started moving on him. The drag when she rose always felt like it was going to turn her inside out, and the plunge back onto him felt like she’d been anchored, pinned to something forever, like a specimen. Cassandra ramped up her speed, but soon she was bouncing on his cock like a wind-up toy.

“Fuck...fuck... Fuck yesss, Cass... Fuck me, girl...”

Dentiger grunted the words out through gritted teeth. She fucked him like a machine, but damn, she made him feel things no other woman ever had. He wasn't foolish enough to think they were soul mates, but he hoped this lasted longer than the mission. He was not ready to give her up.

Cassandra found her rhythm and bounced harder and harder on him. What started as a sharp feeling of being stretched wrapped in an aching pleasure all blurred into an overwhelming sensation when she aggressively pumped her pussy up and down on his cock. She'd never understood the concept of having her *brains fucked out* until she got on top of Dentiger's impressive manhood. A low, rhythmic, incomprehensible moaning matched her thrusts onto him.

"Fuck me... Fuck me, Cass... Take it... Show me...how hard you can fucking take it..."

The night had gotten to both of them, and this was not going to last long—not that they had the kind of relationship that would allow either of them to discuss it, even during sex. Cassandra wished he'd stop talking in general. She was not a dirty talker, and Dentiger's constant stream of obscenities distracted her. She might have had trouble getting there if his cock weren't so incredible.

Her cries climbed in pitch until they became an intense shriek, right before she stopped moving. Cassandra froze with him fully embedded inside her. Her body pulsed with her orgasm, making her sheath flutter around him with the same tempo.

"Yeah...oh fuck yeah... Cass, baby... I'm..."

"No...Tay...not...inside me..."

Dentiger chuckled and lifted Cassandra like she weighed nothing. He understood. They usually used condoms, but they were both too carried away to think about it. That was becoming common after visits to Nox Venari. He loved seeing her control slip, even if it was just a little bit.

Cassandra was on her back, and he took a moment admiring how beautiful she was with her jet hair spilled all over the white sheets beneath her and a flush to her cheeks before he pushed back inside her. She was one of those women who was just naturally pretty without any makeup at all. But he only took a moment.

Dentiger wanted a big finish—even if it would only be a minute or two—so he bent Cassandra’s legs back to her chest. She gasped when he slid his cock back inside her. He pounded it down into her, fucking her just as hard as she’d just fucked him. She began to shriek like she was coming all over again.

“*Awww fuck...*” he cried, lasting even less time than he’d expected.

Pulling out, Dentiger blasted thick ropes of cum all over her quivering body, streaking the flat plane of her stomach and even up onto her small, dark-tipped tits. He pumped his shaft until he’d painted her with everything he had. It might have been even more satisfying to come all over his boss than it would have been to come inside her.

Cassandra smiled and laughed softly while she caught her breath. “Do you have to make such a mess?”

“It has to go somewhere, baby. I could always put it somewhere else...”

“Okay, don’t go there. I need a shower anyway.”

She smoothly swept her legs past him and carefully rolled out of bed without smearing her mess on the sheets. Standing, she stretched to work the soreness out of her thighs. Sex with Dentiger was as good as any workout she could have done in the hotel gym. She felt him watching her and smiled.

“What?” she asked.

“Maybe I just like seeing you naked. Is something wrong with that, Cass?” He rolled onto his back and watched her with his hands behind his head.

“No, I just don’t usually...” She paused but decided to give him a piece of herself anyway. “I don’t usually parade around in front of men—people—naked.”

“If you did, I’m sure they’d appreciate it. You look good, baby.”

Cassandra thought about how Madison let Zaydan strip her in a public part of the club and the way she confidently strode across that bedroom with three men watching her. She wanted to think she could do it if that was her mission, but she wasn’t sure that she could. She envied the redhead’s confidence and freedom even as she judged it. That was something she’d never admit.

“I don’t need to display myself,” she told Dentiger. “Only insecure women do that.”

Dentiger chuckled. “You’re the least insecure woman I’ve ever met, Cass. Want company in the shower?”

“I just want to clean up quickly and get to bed. Tomorrow will be another long day. You should probably get to your room and get to bed, too.” She tossed the words over her shoulder before stepping into the bathroom and sliding the pocket door closed behind her.

Dentiger shook his head and got out of bed to find his pants. He’d never known a woman like Cassandra, and he didn’t think he’d ever understand her. But he was going to enjoy the ride for as long as he could.

seven

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The team was reassembled in the living room of the Rittenhouse Square condo. They'd slept in, and it was late morning, but everyone assembled on the couches was red-eyed and looked hungover.

Kane looked the worst with his stumble and unkempt gray hair. In his vintage black *Dark Side of the Moon* t-shirt and rumpled jeans, he looked like an aging bass player who should have left the road behind long ago. He was only missing the sunglasses.

Madison looked like she hadn't gotten any sleep at all, but with her makeup-free face and red hair pulled back into a ponytail, she just looked like any other suburban mom doing chores around the house in a baggy sweatshirt and Alo yoga pants. She clutched a jumbo coffee mug like it was a talisman.

Manny always looked like he didn't sleep, so that was no change. Dentiger looked almost chipper, and Cassandra vibrated with nervous energy.

They all stared at Bristow, who was on the giant flatscreen over the fireplace. Manny had mounted a small camera above it so the Deputy Director could see the team on the secure video link. It was the first time Madison had seen the woman look so casual. Bristow's dark hair was also

in a ponytail, and she wore a sporty tennis dress, like she'd had to jump off the court to take the call.

"I read your brief, Cass," Bristow said. "It looks to me like everything is going according to plan."

"Except for Reznikov being alive," Madison interjected.

Bristow paused before replying, "That is an unexpected wrinkle. But ultimately, it doesn't change the mission. Scarlet Phantom must proceed."

"And if he shows up? Is Sergei running the organization now, or will Anatoly need to be there for any final deal?" Madison asked.

"I understand your concerns, Sinclair. But we have no reason to believe Anatoly Reznikov will make an appearance," Bristow answered.

"Did you have a reason to believe Anatoly was alive? No one's answered that fucking question?" Kane asked. His tone was angry, but his expression didn't change.

"I looked into the file on that operation," Bristow calmly replied. She hated letting a subordinate speak to her like that—especially a man—but she couldn't afford to antagonize the team. "Reznikov, Sr. appeared to be eliminated in the immediate aftermath, and the Agency didn't look too deeply into it. We were too busy trying to smooth over the killing of a Turkish general."

"I didn't have a choice," Madison interrupted. "Should I have let him rape and kill me?"

"No one is blaming you, Sinclair."

Bristow said that now, but that was not the feeling Madison got when she was interrogated over and over again about the circumstances of General Kemal Arslan's death. She had the distinct impression that the Agency thought she murdered the Turk in some fit of feminine rage because she had to allow him to have his way with her.

"About sixteen months later, we received intel that Reznikov had survived his encounter with you and Kane," Bristow continued. "He was

quietly retired from the Russian army while he recovered. He's shifted his business interests in the years since. We had no reason to believe he was involved with Glacier Flame."

"No one thought to tell me? I thought I killed him."

"The information was classified, Sinclair. Everything about that operation was sealed."

"I had—have—clearance."

"Would knowing have changed anything? Were you grieving because you thought you killed that piece of trash? I know that was a difficult mission. Perhaps the powers-that-be at the time thought reopening those wounds would be worse. He wasn't the first man you killed. And if he'd somehow become a threat to you, the Agency would have alerted you and dealt with it."

Madison admired Bristow's ability to sit there and lie to her face. The Agency didn't care about her mental well-being. That would never be a reason to withhold information. Nor did she believe they would have prioritized telling her there was an issue with Reznikov unless they had no choice.

And yes, she had killed before, but only when she had to. Unlike some agents, taking a life was never easy for her. She remembered every face, all the way back to the first man she killed, Gunnar Müller, then his bodyguard, Tobias. She'd always feared that killing could become too easy. It was one reason she'd known she had to leave the field.

"Can we deal with the past later? We have to figure out what we're doing now," Cassandra said.

"She's right. Kane, Sinclair, I'll show the two of you the Reznikov file later if you want to see it, but we need to proceed with Scarlet Phantom. Is this going to be a problem?" Bristow said.

"Do you have a plan for if Sergei's daddy actually does show up?" Kane asked. "Don't give me the *it was years ago and a different context* bullshit.

Anatoly will recognize Maddy if he sees her. You don't forget people who shoot you in the head."

"Or if it clicks for Sergei and he remembers who I am?" Madison added.

"I really don't think that's likely, guys," Bristow started.

"Cass and I are right outside. Don't worry, if scary Daddy Reznikov shows up, we'll be right inside, guns blazing. We'll save your asses," Dentiger said. "You know this is the CIA, right? Not the Girl Scouts."

"Tay, don't antagonize them," Cass warned.

"Yeah, I feel so much better knowing a dumb asshole like you has my back," Kane replied.

"Are you all children? Do you have control of your team, Cass?" Bristow scolded from the screen.

Cassandra glared at Dentiger. She expected him to have her back, and not just because they were sleeping together. Well, maybe it was a little bit because they were having sex.

"I've got this, ma'am."

Bristow stared at the Scarlet Phantom team on her laptop. She was in her home office. It didn't bother her that she had to get involved on a Saturday—being Deputy Director of the CIA wasn't a 9-to-5 job. But she resented that she had to get involved because a team of highly trained officers couldn't act like professionals.

"This is what's going to happen," Bristow told the team. "Sinclair, Kane, stand down and take a minute to cool off. Just for tonight, we'll activate Plan B so we can have eyes in Nox Venari."

"Wait a minute. There's a Plan B? What is Plan B?" Madison said, sitting forward so abruptly that she nearly spilled her coffee.

"We have a secondary option for Nox Venari, but it's primarily a surveillance plan. It's not designed to hook the prince," Cassandra replied.

“I thought I had to do this because there was no other option. You’ve had this in your back pocket the whole time?”

Madison fumed. She felt like Bristow had been manipulating her since she’d walked into the younger woman’s office. The Agency always had a contingency, but she hadn’t thought Bristow was holding back part of the mission plan. That made no sense from an operational standpoint unless she was holding back even more information. Madison wondered if Bristow was lying about Sergei Reznikov, too. *Does she want me there because Sergei is involved? Why would she want that?* Madison knew better than to give in to paranoia, but she had no sleep and didn’t know what to believe anymore. This whole mission felt like a cruel joke.

“We also had Cass and Dentiger admitted to Nox Venari as a couple, just as a fallback. We did not plan to insert them unless things got hot and we needed them on site,” Bristow explained. “It’s just a contingency.”

Madison gaped at her handler and the muscular Black officer. They’d known the whole time that they could go into Nox Venari, and they said nothing? Maybe it was because they just weren’t believable as a couple. She didn’t see it. It was a problem, but she and Kane had just as much chemistry as ever.

“Are you going to go in there and pound Cass, buddy?” Kane smirked.

“Listen, motherfucker...” Dentiger warned.

“I can see it, I totally see you two fucking, but...”

“Enough!” Bristow shouted. “That is enough. I will be on the first Acela to New York, and I will run point in the van with Sanz. Hopefully, Cass and Dentiger can get close enough to keep our intel fresh. Sinclair, go home and get your act together. But we will need you back. Cass is not going to be able to hook Prince Zaydan the way you can. We need you.”

Cassandra didn’t know whether she should be relieved that Bristow didn’t expect her to sleep with the prince or offended that she didn’t think Cassandra could seduce him. She had no desire to take Madison’s role, but

she liked to think that she could get Prince Zaydan in bed if she had to. *I'm hot. He should be so lucky.*

Dentiger relished the opportunity to get out of the SUV and into the action. *Let those washed-up fucks go home. We've got this*, he thought. He looked at Cassandra and tried to imagine having to watch her fuck that maggot al-Kharabati. It would turn his stomach—he had no idea how Kane did it, if he really cared about Madison—but he knew how sexy Cassandra was. Dentiger had no doubt she could have the prince if she wanted him. That bastard should be so lucky.

Manny was just sick at the thought of having to spend the night in the van with the Deputy Director. He didn't need that kind of stress.

"What am I doing in this?" Kane asked.

"Do you need the night off to get your shit together?" Bristow asked.

"I'm always good to go," he replied.

"Then you can be in Dentiger's usual place. You all have your orders. Get to it," Bristow said, closing the video link.

"Well, shit. I guess it's time to bring in the A-team," Dentiger said, chuckling.

Madison slammed her mug down on the coffee table and stormed out of the living room. She couldn't get out of there fast enough.

THE WORLD HAD SHIFTED in the last few weeks.

When Operation Scarlet Phantom was first pressed on Madison, her return to fieldwork felt alien, like she was being pressed into a world where she didn't belong. Coming home had been her refuge. Sixteen years was a long time to be away from anything, and she thought she'd never be at ease working with her new team—especially because Kane was part of it.

Over the last few weeks, Madison had been spending as much time in Philadelphia and New York as she had at home in McLean, and the balance of her life had changed. The Uber ride through her leafy suburban neighborhood felt all wrong. It felt like she was slipping into a role, not coming home.

She set down her bag in the big, quiet house she shared with Charles and the kids, and she felt like she didn't belong. She looked at the family photos on the wall and thought they could have been fakes cooked up by the Agency's wizards just as easily as the photos made to get her and Kane accepted as members of Nox Venari. Madison Sinclair, the Langley analyst and suburban mom, was starting to feel like the cover identity.

Charles' car was not in the driveway, but that made sense. He was managing their kids' schedules and keeping their lives going while she was out saving the world. He'd done it all without—well, with minimal—complaint. She'd fled the Rittenhouse Square condo so quickly that she hadn't even texted Charles to let him know she was on her way home.

Madison went straight through to the kitchen and poured herself a large glass of wine. She had no idea what time it was; everything had started to blur together. She just needed something to help her feel normal.

She was contemplating another shower—she'd already showered twice since leaving Nox Venari last night—when Penny walked into the kitchen. Her daughter eyed the glass of wine critically. Madison glanced at the clock on the microwave; it was only a little after five. Penny breezed through like she wasn't surprised to find Madison there.

"Oh, hey, Mom. When did you get back?" Penny asked, grabbing an Uncrustable from the freezer.

"Just a couple of minutes ago. Didn't you hear me come in?"

"No. I just came down for a snack." She took a glass from the cupboard and filled it with water and ice from the dispenser on the refrigerator, maneuvering around her mother.

“I can see that. Aren’t you going to let that thing thaw first?”

“Why? I like them better this way.”

“That’s hard on your teeth, honey. Maybe pop it in the microwave.”

“Don’t need to,” Penny replied on her way out of the kitchen.

“Hey, aren’t we eating dinner soon? Isn’t that going to ruin your appetite?” Madison called after her.

“Dad won’t be back with Chaz for another hour. Chill, Mom. I’m hungry now.”

Penny turned the corner to the stairs, moving out of sight.

Madison wanted to call her daughter back. Part of her wanted to chastise the kid for blowing her off, but she didn’t want to start a thing. She understood that her sudden absence was hard on the kids, even if Penny acted indifferent to her presence most of the time.

Their relationship had become rocky when Penny entered her teenage years, and Madison guiltily thought that at least the girl was showing some kind of sign that she still needed her mother. She did not want her relationship with Penny to be like the relationship she’d had with her own mother; by the time she was sixteen, Madison had been raising herself. Her mother had been completely disengaged.

Instead of going after Penny, she leaned back against the kitchen counter and gulped down her glass of wine, refilling it as soon as it was empty.

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Charles only knew Madison was back because Penny casually mentioned it when she bounced down to the kitchen to see what he'd brought home for dinner. She'd dug through the bag, looking for her favorites from their local Thai place, and tossed off, "Oh, by the way, Mom's back," as she reached for a plate in the cupboard. Penny loved knowing things other people didn't. She was more like her mother than either of them would ever admit.

He wondered which version of his wife he was getting back this time. When she was home, he saw her attempting to be the same old Madison. She was bright and smiling and fun, but in her unguarded moments, he saw the wariness. Madison looked like the whole world was against her sometimes. It was in those candid moments that he'd always thought he was seeing the real her.

That side of Madison still came out sometimes. He'd see her staring into the darkness in their backyard at night or blanking out on some boring politician's story and realize the new version of herself that she'd carefully constructed over the course of their marriage was still hiding the girl who was trying to decide between fight and flight.

Charles never asked her about it because he knew she'd never give him a real answer, and he understood that people had the right to keep parts of

themselves private. He certainly had parts of himself that he didn't want anyone to see.

Whatever it was the CIA had her doing, it was slowly chipping away at the woman Madison had worked so hard to become. He hated the Agency for it. Gently prodding his old contacts from his Justice Department days hadn't yielded any information, which only confirmed what he'd always suspected. Whatever his wife really did for the government, it was top secret at the highest levels.

He hated going through back channels to try and find out what Madison was doing, but she would stick to her cover story if he asked, and then he'd get angry at her for lying, even though he understood she had no choice. But the woman the CIA had sent back to him was not the same one it had taken.

After calling out Madison's name and getting no response, he asked Penny, "Do you know where she is?"

Penny shrugged. "I dunno. She must be here somewhere. It's a big house."

"I can go find her, Dad," Chaz said. The boy just missed his mother and wanted to see her.

"That's okay, champ. Eat your dinner. She's probably upstairs. I'll go see if she wants to come down and eat with us."

Madison didn't hear Charles, he discovered, because she was upstairs in the master bath, enjoying their whirlpool tub with the jets blasting on full power. A mostly empty glass of wine sat on the ledge beside the tub. She didn't even notice him when he opened the bathroom door. He was about to call out to her when he paused.

They'd been together almost eighteen years, and he still couldn't quite believe she was his. He swore she hadn't aged a day since he'd put that ring on her finger—or if she had, she'd only become more beautiful, sexier.

Charles liked that her body was fuller now. She'd been a little too hard when they'd first met. Sometimes he'd been bruised after they'd had sex.

Madison took a deep breath, and her pale breasts peeked out of the bubbling water. Her tits were perfect. He knew she'd never agree, but they were hotter at forty-eight than they'd been in her thirties. He'd fight anyone—except for her—who said otherwise.

One of her long legs was out of the water, too, and her heel rested on the ridge of the tub. Just those two accidental exposures of skin were enough to stir Charles in his salmon-colored shorts. Their sex life had taken a serious hit because of her work schedule. Watching her, he suspected Madison wasn't holding out for him to come home to take care of things.

Her eyes were closed, and her pink lips parted. Charles could have sworn a soft moan escaped those lips, but the tub's jets were too loud to be sure. Her tongue peeked out the way it always did when she was deep in thought. Her hands were both beneath the steaming, bubbling water. He was sure his wife was touching herself.

God, she's a sexy woman, he thought, despite feeling left out. She didn't have to do that. She could have waited until he got home. His worries about her state of mind slipped away as he crept closer to the tub for a better look.

Spying on Madison getting herself off felt dirty and wrong. He knew he should announce himself at the very least, but he was enthralled. Watching something he shouldn't see was thrilling. He was already fully hard.

Charles was halfway to the tub when she smiled, eyes still closed, and said, "You might as well be wearing tap shoes, honey."

"How did you know it was me?" He froze in his tracks.

"That rugby injury you got back in college left you with the slightest hitch in your step. Besides..." She paused for a soft gasp. "No one else had better be sneaking up on me in the bathtub."

"I can think of a lot of guys who'd love to see what I'm seeing right now."

“Really?” One of her eyebrows went up, but her eyes stayed closed.

“Well, there’s Bill van Holt for one, but he’d never dare sneak up on you. Not after what you did to him in that snack bar.”

Madison’s laugh melted into a low moan. “Let that be a lesson to anyone who sneaks up on me with impure thoughts.”

“Uh-oh. I’m in trouble.”

“You’re my husband. You have carte blanche for all the impure thoughts you’d like to have.”

“But I’m sorry about sneaking up on you. Seriously, Maddy. I should have told you I was here.”

“You weren’t sneaking, honey. I thought I made that clear.”

Charles tried to process that, and his worries nagged at the edge of his mind. She knew he was there and kept going anyway. Did he even want to know how whatever she was doing for the CIA could lead to her doing that? One of the most baffling changes in Madison over the last month or so had been in her sex drive.

Their sex life had taken a hit because she simply wasn’t around very often, but when she was home, Madison had been transformed into a nymphomaniac. Sometimes she was bouncing off the walls, and sometimes she was so tired she barely remembered her own name, but the one constant was that when she was home, Madison wanted sex. It was even weirder when she was exhausted. She would just lie there and ask Charles to take her.

Madison finally opened her eyes and looked at him. The need in them almost frightened him. “Why are you staying all the way over there, honey? Come closer if you want to see.”

Charles was drawn to her like she had her own gravitational pull. Standing over the bubbling tub, he thought he saw her hands moving under the water. He sat on the ledge, entranced by the beautiful, naked redhead touching herself in the tub.

“I don’t mind if you watch, but you should ask,” she said, one wet hand rising from the water to cover his.

“Maddy, are you okay?”

He didn’t want to ruin the mood. His cock certainly didn’t want him to, but it was hard to ignore how out of character her behavior was. She needed to know that she could tell him if something was going on. They could get through anything together, even the darker things he thought about on those lonely nights in bed when Madison was out doing God knew what.

“Don’t I look okay?” She had a slight slur, making him wonder how many glasses of wine she’d had. “I think I look pretty damn good right now.”

“Yeah, you look really good,” he agreed.

She stretched to reach for his lap, her wet hand leaving a visible trail of drips across the salmon fabric of his shorts. She only just managed to brush the lump there before he moved her hand back.

“Careful, Maddy. It’s going to look like I pissed myself.”

“Or you did something else in your shorts,” she giggled.

“It will be weird if I have to change before I go back downstairs.” That reminded him that the kids were eating.

Before he could tell Madison that he’d brought dinner home, she pulled his hand into the water, nearly making him topple into the tub on top of her. Charles regained his balance just in time, but the front of his seafoam green polo was soaked.

“Hey...” he complained.

His protest cut off when he felt the slickness between her thighs. She moaned deeply when he pressed his fingers into her furrow. Charles felt like he was half in the tub and tried to pull his hand back, but she caught his wrist with an iron grip that was almost painful. *When did she get so strong?* he wondered.

“Maddy...the kids are downstairs...they’re waiting for us...for dinner...”

Charles found it difficult to form a coherent argument when she was forcing him to circle his fingers over her clit. She moaned and arched her back, thrusting her breasts out of the water. They looked perfectly ripe with the water running down off them.

“Charles...don’t...I need this...”

“Maddy...”

“Please...ahhh...finish me...need to...feel you...”

The couple hung there in the moment, Charles torn between what he thought was responsible parenting and what he wanted to do—which was climb into the tub with his wife, and Madison desperately needing a connection to her husband—even if it was only him making her come with his hand.

Madison felt shameless, rolling her hips to work her pussy on his hand, but she was so close. It was a side of her that he hadn’t seen in years—and even then rarely. She’d tried to keep it hidden from him, afraid a man like Charles wouldn’t understand. By the time she knew he wouldn’t judge her because he was a good man, she was already trying to be someone else—to be better for him.

But Prince Zaydan had seen that side of her at Nox Venari. As had Kane—again—and everyone else watching—the prince’s bodyguard, Manny and Cassandra in the van, Dentiger watching alone in the SUV. They saw how easily she came for Zaydan. Could they tell that wasn’t Madison playing a role?

“Yesss...god...hon...almost...there...”

She’d broken her marriage vows over and over again that weekend at the elite sex club. Madison didn’t expect Charles to understand that she was doing it for their country. It felt like a thin excuse. Uncle Sam didn’t make her come for Zaydan or enjoy having Kane back inside her the way that she

did. And now she needed some connection to her husband—any connection—to feel like she hadn't destroyed everything. It didn't matter that Charles didn't know. *She knew.*

Madison looked into his stormy gray eyes behind his glasses. She hated that she saw as much concern there as she saw lust, but it didn't matter. Charles knew exactly how to touch her. He curled two fingers inside her at the perfect angle while she rubbed her clit, and she went off.

"Yes! Yes! Ohmygod...yes!"

Her cries echoed off the tiles of their large bathroom. She abruptly curled into a ball, splashing the hot, bubbling water, and nearly dragged Charles into the water again when she jerked his arm forward.

"Hey! Maddy!"

Charles pulled his hand from between her thighs and sat up, but the damage was already done. He was soaked. Huffing, he took his glasses off to dry them, but couldn't find a dry enough spot on his shirt.

"Sorry," she murmured, followed by a light laugh. "Okay, not really sorry."

"You're not the one who got soaked," he complained.

Madison laughed harder. The endorphin rush from her orgasm provided exactly the lightness she needed. "I beg to differ, and I'm not talking about the bath. Do I need to prove it to you again?"

He allowed a little grin. She knew she had him and rose out of the tub. His eyes were glued to the water running off her breasts. A lot of men had seen her tits that weekend. Madison pushed the thought down, focused on her husband.

"I think I do," she continued, wrapping her dripping arms around his neck and pressing her soaked body against him.

Charles cracked and laughed against her lips. "Okay...okay. I surrender." He firmly gripped her slick ass with both hands.

The couple shared a long, slow, deep kiss, the kind that made Madison's chest tight. It was a kiss that reminder her that no matter what she did at Nox Venari, *this* was her home. Charles was her life. She knew he felt it, too, and hoped that it dispelled some of his fears. *I'm still yours*, she thought. *No matter what I have to do up there in New York.*

"Are you sure you don't want proof of how wet I am, honey?" she teased, sliding a hand between them to knead the front of his shorts. "It feels like you do."

"Christ, you have no idea, Maddy," he groaned, trying to pull away from her. "But the kids are right downstairs. Awake. Waiting for at least one of us to eat with them."

"I promise, I can make sure it's quick." Madison was confident she could get him off in record time. He looked like it wouldn't take much to push him over the edge.

"Later. We won't have to be quick once the kids are in bed. Come on, honey. Be reasonable."

Madison sighed. She admired his self-control, but part of her resented him for it. *Damien would be bending me over the side of this tub right now.* She felt guilty for even thinking it and let Charles go. But she couldn't see her partner being a responsible parent like her husband. She couldn't imagine Kane as a father at all. That was part of why she'd made the choice she did all those years ago.

"Okay," she replied, trying not to sound as disappointed as she felt.

Charles gave her a quick peck. "I'm going to change. Will you come down and eat with us?"

The thought of shifting into domestic mom mode gave her whiplash, but she smiled and replied, "Yeah. I just need a minute to drain the tub and get dressed."

"Are you really okay, Maddy?" he asked.

"Fine. Just tired."

Charles didn't believe her, but it wasn't the time to get into it. Sooner or later, they were going to have to find that time.

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Cassandra stared at the blinking cursor on her screen. She felt like it was mocking her, whispering *liar* with every blink. The after-action report she was writing about their Saturday night at Nox Venari was not a lie. It wasn't even inaccurate. But it was not the whole truth. Luckily, the Agency didn't care about the *whole* truth—at least, not as she perceived it. Just like on *Dragnet*, *just the facts, ma'am* was enough.

The antiseptic report laid out the facts. Cassandra and Dentiger entered the club as Tessa and Malik Sanders, new members from Connecticut. Tessa was a very successful engineer with a defense contractor. Malik was a former Special Forces operator who now worked private security. The couple met on the job. Their cover explained the couple's lack of social media presence, which required much less background work from the Agency to create the legend for their identities.

The Sanders did not stick together in the same way that the Richardsons—Madison and Kane's cover—did at the club. They were much more confident and presented as an experience Lifestyle couple. Bristow thought they could cover more ground that way.

Cassandra found it ironic that Madison was playing reticent while she was acting like a hedonist. Neither woman was playing toward their real personality, in her opinion.

Prince Zaydan bin Zayman al-Kharabati was at Nox Venari, as promised, with his usual goon in tow. Sergei Reznikov was also in attendance, accompanied by two other Russians. His father was nowhere in sight. The team concluded that meant their assumption that the sale of the quantum cipher, Null:Echo would be taking place within the privacy of the exclusive sex club.

Dentiger and Cassandra stayed as close as they could to the parties while they were in the public areas of Nox Venari. They overheard the prince asking the club's owner, Cora Ludolf, if the Richardsons were expected. Such membership information was allegedly strictly confidential, but the rules were different for men like Zaydan. At least, he seemed disappointed when he was informed that his favorite MILF was not on the guest list for the evening, which was a win for the Scarlet Phantom team.

Staying with the prince and the Russians proved trickier than anticipated. Tessa and Malik were very popular with the other members of Nox Venari, which was where Cassandra's report was light on details. She could have shared how it was difficult to eavesdrop on the targets because men were constantly chatting with her, and how she occasionally lost focus when she shifted into playing her role as a sexy swinger. There was no need to detail the ways she allowed men to casually touch her that she never would have tolerated in real life. But on Saturday night, she was Tessa, not Cassandra.

Other details of the night had been recorded in her personal journal, but no one would ever read that. The journal was her safe place. Only in that black leather-bound book did she admit how that kind of attention felt.

Cassandra was attractive, and she was used to men hitting on her, but real life was nothing like what went on at Nox Venari. She'd also never put it out there like that before. A petite Asian woman was very popular in the sex club. Bristow had insisted on taking her shopping once the decision had been made that Cassandra was going into the club, and the younger woman

felt like her mom was taking her shopping for a prom dress. She was also vaguely insulted at Bristow's suggestion that she needed help, but the Deputy Director had correctly surmised that they were going well outside Cassandra's comfort zone. The team leader would play it safe if left to her own devices.

The tiny, black velvet cocktail dress was certainly something Cassandra never would have chosen. She both felt like she couldn't breathe in it and was half-naked. She'd never even considered going out in public wearing so little. But Bristow had been right. The dress had the desired effect. The men of Nox Venari were all over Cassandra.

They were forward and openly sexual in ways that would get a man on the street slapped. They stared at her breasts while they made small talk, not even pretending they weren't mentally undressing her. She had to keep reminding herself to play along because Tessa would not be offended. Tessa *sought* that kind of attention from men. Soon, the buzzing between her legs was very real. Her flushed cheeks were not the result of method acting.

And the touches. Letting men casually touch her like they had the right was not her thing at all. She even took charge in bed with Dentiger. But the brushes against her hand, the casual caresses of her bare arm or shoulder, the possessive hands on her hip. A handsome, older man had steered Cassandra away from the bar with a hand that slid down to her ass, and she'd felt like she could hardly breathe. When he'd kissed her, she'd told herself that it was Tessa who kissed him back. Only her journal knew the truth about that.

Dentiger's luck wasn't much better when it came to sticking with the targets. The muscular young black man may have been even more in demand than his partner—especially among the older women who were plentiful at Nox Venari.

Cora Ludolf herself seemed particularly enamored of her newest member. When he was being overwhelmed by a group of five women vying

for his attention—which he did not mind at all—the grand dame of Nox Venari swooped in and escorted Dentiger to safety. Cassandra watched it from across the room, where she had her own set of admirers. The attention didn't lessen her jealousy when she saw her fake husband leave with the icy British blonde.

That was nothing compared to the rage she felt when she caught up with Dentiger, only to find him in a corner receiving what appeared to be a world-class blowjob from the former model. Cassandra wanted to yank Cora away from Dentiger by her long, swaying white-blonde ponytail. Instead, she leaned back against the wall, arms crossed, and watched.

Dentiger spotted her, and she swore he looked like he was going to push Cora away. But his large cock was halfway down the blonde's throat, and the poor guy didn't have the willpower. He never broke eye contact with his partner. Cassandra smirked when she watched him spill into Cora's mouth.

Of course she's good at it, Cassandra had thought. *She's a slut. She's probably practiced on a thousand dicks.* She thought she was quite good and didn't need all the sleeping around. She'd had less than she could count on two hands.

Cassandra left him there to finish with Cora, angry at herself for her jealousy. They were just work partners. The sex thing with him was casual. Dentiger was free to put his cock wherever he wanted. It was only her business if he caught something from tomcatting around and gave it to her.

Her confusion was as strong as her jealousy and anger. Cassandra didn't understand why watching that blowjob left her pussy soaked. She was above such things. Wasn't she?

No useful intel was gleaned from the outing. Neither spy heard a mention of Null:Echo from their targets. Cassandra assumed that was saved for when the men, along with several of Nox Venari's paid models, retired upstairs to VIP area that was reserved for the club's Obsidianus members.

Prince Zaydan never once looked Cassandra's way, so an invitation up to the lounge was out of the question. The spy grudgingly admitted that Bristow was right. They needed Madison.

"HAVE you stopped to see any family while you've been here?" Madison asked. "It must be nice to be back home."

"It's not really home anymore, Maddy. It hasn't been home since I quit school and joined the Army," Kane said.

"But you still have family here, don't you?"

"I have a brother over the river in South Jersey. He's got a wife, a couple kids. We haven't talked in years. I don't think anyone is looking for Uncle Damien to show up. I can't regale them with stories stopping a chemical attack or tossing a terrorist out of a plane, and making up a life for them would be exhausting. I don't know how you do it."

"We don't live the same life anymore, Damien. I can't be candid about my work, but I don't have to lie. At least, I didn't before now."

"Are you missing the desk?"

Madison stared out into the park. Rittenhouse Square was one of several planned green spaces in downtown Philadelphia. The parks were part of the meticulously planned original section of the city and went all the way back to colonial times. The modern iteration of the space was beautifully landscaped, with brick paths, sculptures, and a lovely fountain. It was a perfect escape from the craziness of the city around them.

That city was scorching on that June afternoon. It was somehow reassuring to know that Philadelphia was every bit as gross and swampy on a summer day as DC was just a few hours to the south. Madison felt like she'd brought a piece of home with her. She sipped her iced coffee and answered Kane.

“Yes. No. I don’t know. I miss my real life, but the longer this goes on, the more I feel detached from it. It’s been too easy to fall back into our—*my*—old life.” She needed to change the subject. “I really think you should see your brother while you’re here. It’s never too late to reconnect.”

Kane laughed mirthlessly and sipped his own coffee. Black. Hot. “Would you swing by your mom’s if you were up in Beantown?”

Madison managed to look sad and relieved all at once. “She wouldn’t recognize me if I did. She’s been in an assisted living facility up there for about five years. Alzheimer’s isn’t something I’d wish on anyone—even her.”

“I think about that stuff more, the older I get. Doesn’t matter how well you take care of yourself. Whatever is going to happen is going to happen. Can’t outrun time.”

“Are you claiming you’ve taken good care of yourself?” Madison laughed.

“Not really.” He smiled. “Although a lot of the wear and tear is work-related.” Kane didn’t hide his admiration for Madison when he looked her over. He thought they were past pretending about anything. She looked incredible in that light summery dress with her copper hair up in a ponytail and not a drop of makeup. She was every inch the sexy suburban mom. “Looking at you is a great argument for getting behind a desk. You don’t have all the hard miles I have.”

Madison took his hand and squeezed it. Being around Kane had become as comfortable as ever. She didn’t want to think it was because they’d slept together again. She was trying—and failing—to not think about that at all.

“I think you’ve aged pretty well, Damien. Don’t be so hard on yourself.”

“Maybe like a fine whiskey,” he conceded.

“How did it go on Saturday night? I read Cass’s report. It doesn’t look like much happened, but I got the feeling she left some pieces of the

evening out of it. I asked Manny if I could review the video, and he told me he wasn't finished processing it, whatever that means."

Kane gave her that smirk again. "It means I think there are parts of the night Cass would rather no one knows about. They weren't related to the case, but I saw a whole new side to our fearless leader when she went into Nox Venari."

"Really? I didn't think the bookworm had it in her."

Kane filled Dentiger's usual role that night, dropping the couple off at the front door and then sitting in the SUV watching the video feed from their covert cameras, ready to go in if they needed backup. Of course, he had to sit there in his tuxedo because he could enter the club as David Richardson—although he would have needed to make up an excuse for why "Melissa" wasn't with him that evening.

"Listen, she didn't go crazy. Cass didn't strip or go off with some stranger..." Kane paused, in case Madison thought he was calling *her* a slut. "But our little girl came out of her shell. She likes to walk around with her nose in the air like she's above it all, but she likes attention as much as anyone else. She looked hot in that dress Bristow picked for her."

Unfortunately, Kane only had the view from the camera in the locket that Madison had worn into the club before Cassandra. Dentiger wasn't around enough to give another view of what she was up to. But he was surprised that Cassandra hung around to watch Dentiger get blown by Cora Ludolf. Kane didn't take her for a voyeur. From the way her respiration elevated, she liked what she saw.

Kane, however, was a little disappointed that Cora seemed to hand out blowjobs like candy on Halloween. That made his a little less special.

"She looked hot, huh?" Madison asked.

"Y'know, for Cass. She wasn't in her standard uniform."

"I'm just teasing you," she replied, elbowing him in the ribs. "I'm not jealous. I'm a married woman. You could sleep with Cass if you want to. I

don't think it's a good idea, but whatever."

Kane didn't buy her casual tone, but didn't push it. "I think our boy Tay may already be in there. They've got some kind of weird energy between them."

Madison considered it. She hadn't picked up on a thing between Cassandra and Dentiger, but she'd been distracted. Good for her, if it was true. Madison had no time for the man, but he was in incredible shape. If she were younger and single, she would bed him just to try and neutralize the aggression between them.

"Huh. They don't seem like a match, but maybe it's just one of those mission things."

"Sometimes those mission things last longer than the mission."

She didn't take the bait. "Did Cass try to engage Zay?"

"He's Zay now?" Kane arched an eyebrow.

"He said to call him that. Stop it." She looked away and hoped he read the flush of her cheeks as the heat getting to her.

Kane felt the same discomfort he'd always experienced when Madison got close to a target. He knew how she got, how hard she threw herself into her work, how much she enjoyed certain aspects of it. He had no right to feel uncomfortable now, but old habits died hard.

"No, I don't think he looked her way once, except maybe to see who all those guys were gathered around. But I think Sergei may have liked the chance to get to know her."

"That's something to keep in our back pocket," Madison replied, secretly pleased that the prince had no interest in her younger handler. "Hopefully, *Zaydan* doesn't close this deal with the Russians too quickly, and we get another shot at this."

"About that. Listen, Maddy, if you don't want to go back in there, I'll have your back. They can't force us to do it if we're willing to take the heat."

“We’d be ending our careers, Damien. I’d never ask you to do that.”

“I don’t care. It’s rotten that they’d even ask. It’s rotten that they never told us that Reznikov was still alive.”

“You know the Agency doesn’t feel like it owes us an explanation for anything.”

“I don’t really give a fuck what they think.”

Walking away had its appeal. Madison could go home and be truly free for the first time in her life. They could probably get by on Charles’s salary. She could become one of those comfortable McLean stay-at-home moms and do all the community activities she didn’t have time for now, go to yoga and Pilates three times a week. Ending up fucking her personal trainer. She thought the last with a smile. And if she did want to work, Madison was sure she could find something, even if the Agency blacklisted her.

But she couldn’t. The stakes with Null:Echo were too high. None of the facts that convinced her to go back into the field had changed. If the Kharabatis passed that cipher to their terrorist networks, it was all over. They could shut off water systems, meltdown reactors. They could destroy the financial markets. Or worse, they could penetrate military networks and set off the next world war. Madison wasn’t the type of person who could walk away from that.

“No, Damien. We have to do this. I don’t want to live in a world where Null:Echo is out there. Do you?”

Kane flashed that familiar grin that made Madison want to drop her panties. It had the same charm sixteen years later. “Eh, you know me. I can’t let the bad guys win. I’m too stubborn.”

Madison took a deep sigh and drained her iced coffee. “Then I guess we’d better get back to work.”

“Yeah, I guess we should,” Kane agreed, wishing he had a shot of whiskey in his coffee.

They started the walk back to the condo. Madison took his hand, twining her fingers in his. The seasoned spies looked like any other couple out for a lunchtime stroll in Rittenhouse Square.

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“**A**nd the guru taught us this technique, you’re both lying on your sides, using your lips and tongues to pleasure each other, but you’re also trying to keep your breathing in sync. And if you’re ready to come, but they aren’t, you have to keep control and prevent yourself from going off. It’s really quite remarkable.”

Madison was half paying attention. She really wished the man—she thought he said his name was Shel, or Mel, or something like that—would stop talking. He’d been trying to sell her on the virtues of tantric sex for the last half hour, but the last thing she was interested in was learning tantric sex from a short, heavysset man with a flemmy rattle to his voice who was old enough to be her father.

“It’s magical with your partner, of course,” he continued. “Janice and I have been doing it for almost twenty years. But when you do it with a chain of three or four people—trust me, Melissa—it’s truly a spiritual experience. Imagine how hard it is to get four people to all come at the same time! You’re denying your orgasm forever, so when you finally do come, you break into a million pieces.”

“I don’t know...” she paused before calling him *Shel* because, despite her annoyance, she didn’t want to hurt his feelings if she had it wrong.

Instead, she sipped her Revolver cocktail before continuing. “Refusing to let myself have an orgasm over and over again for...how long can this go on, an hour, hours...sounds like absolute torture. That’s no fun at all. I would hate that.”

“You’d be surprised,” he argued. Shel-or-Mel had salesman-on-coke energy, despite his age.

“I don’t think I would. I know my own body. I’ve done things.” She smiled.

Melissa Richardson probably hadn’t done much out of the ordinary, but Madison Sinclair knew what she was talking about. One of her first undercover assignments had been to infiltrate the organization of a German money launderer, and the way in had been to be his eye candy and plaything for a few months.

Life on Herr Müller’s yacht off the Greek coast had been cushy. She spent her days lounging around in a bikini, and her nights going to the hottest clubs, but her host had a very particular way he liked to enjoy his girls. Fortunately, he wasn’t one of those freaks who liked to hurt women.

No, he was all about pleasure. Denied and imposed. And for reasons she’d never understood, Madison was his favorite subject to watch being tormented with pleasure.

She learned a lot about herself on that yacht. How much she enjoyed the touch of another woman. Just how hard she could come at the hands of an expert. And as strong and stubborn as she was, Madison learned that someone with the right skills and patience could make her beg. She’d never begged in bed before, and she’d rarely done it since.

Unfortunately, the suggestion that she’d *done things* only piqued Shel-or-Mel’s interest. “Do tell. I’d love to hear about your experiences.”

“That would be lovely, but I really should find my husband before he gets himself into trouble.”

Madison knew exactly where Kane was. She'd been watching him in deep conversation with Cora Ludolf in on the other side of the large performance room. Although she was masked like every other guest, there was no mistaking the former model's willowy form—particularly in the sheer lace body stocking she was strutting around in. *Maybe if I had a body like hers, I'd do that, too*, she thought.

The performance space at Nox Venari was more subdued than on their previous visits. Instead of people having sex on the elevated dais, singles, couples, and groups were posing on the dais for Erotic Sketch Night.

Models had been hired to pose, but club members were only encouraged to take to the dais if they felt so moved. A signup sheet was posted near the doorway. Over a dozen people moved around the room with large sketch pads and pencils or charcoal.

A thick Hispanic woman and an absolutely cut white man were currently posing. She was in a deep bend, with her forearms resting on the bed and her ass high in the air. Her pendulous breasts hung alluringly. Madison was impressed by how long she could hold the pose. The man stood behind her, hand on the small of her back. Madison couldn't tell if he was inside her or not.

Shel-or-Mel placed a hand on Madison's arm as she stepped away from the bar. "I'm sure he's fine. One can only get into good trouble here."

"Either way, I'd rather be there when it happens," she replied, squeezing his wrist with more force than necessary when she peeled his hand from her arm.

A bell tinkled as she walked toward Kane and Cora. The dinner bell signaled that it was time to change models. The woman on the dais pushed upright and stretched, undisturbed by brushing against the large, condom-sheathed erection sported by the man. *Yep, he was inside her*, Madison thought. She had no idea how he stayed inside that beautiful woman for that

long and held perfectly still. *They have to be going off to fuck*, she thought. The crowd applauded the couple.

Cora walked away from Kane just as Madison arrived. The blonde took the stage and informed her guests that they would resume after a ten-minute break.

“Having fun, darling?” Kane asked, sliding his hand over the exposed small of Madison’s back, giving her goosebumps. His kiss tasted like expensive single malt. He was fully enjoying the perks of being a Nox Venari member.

“Always,” she replied, resting her hand firmly on his butt. Acting like his wife was becoming disconcertingly easy. Although she never would have casually groped Charles’s butt like that in public—he would turn four shades of crimson. “It looked like you and Cora were having an intense conversation.”

“She was trying to convince me to go up there with her. She promised to make it worth my while.”

“Did she now? You should have gone.”

Kane grinned. “I don’t think I’m the model type.”

Madison turned his head and ran her fingers along his smooth jawline. He was only clean-shaven when he played David Richardson. He looked like an unmade bed most of the time, but he still cut a dashing figure in a tuxedo, much to her chagrin. She knew she shouldn’t notice such things.

“I think you’d look good up there.” She played with edge of his unbuttoned jacket. “Get out of this monkey suit. I’m sure the ladies of Nox Venari would appreciate it.” She thought of Shel-or-Mel. “You’re one of the hotter guys here.”

“Give the ladies a thrill?” His fingers danced up her spine, making her core tighten. Sixteen years apart, and he still knew how to touch her.

“I think we all deserve it.”

“Will you reward me?”

“What about Cora?”

“Who says I can’t have both?”

“Greedy, aren’t you?”

“How about this? I’ll go up there if you do. I can go put your name on the list right now.” Kane suggested.

Madison pulled him down into a long, slow kiss that spread heat down her chest. She didn’t think. She just acted. Her tongue was still teasing his when she pulled away. Only then did she think, *You’re Melissa. He’s David.*

The task was to be a convincing married couple, and the Richardsons should be getting more comfortable with being at Nox Venari. They should be playful, in Madison’s mind. She was well aware that the team could hear and see everything they did, and that would be her justification if anyone tried to say something. But her dirty little secret was that she’d rediscovered how much she liked kissing Kane.

Madison keenly felt the contrast between her two husbands. As things got easier with Kane, they were becoming more strained with Charles, her *actual* husband. Her weekend at home with her family in McLean had been strange, at best.

Charles kept asking her if she was okay, to the point that it was creating friction between them. She resented that he wouldn’t just leave her alone. The resentment was easier to deal with than her guilt. He was frustrated that Madison was clearly lying every time she said that she was fine. They knew each other too well for him to buy that nonsense.

The mission was slowly pulling them apart. She could only hope they’d find their way back to each other when it was over. Madison would bury her guilt over what she had to do. She’d learned to live with worse.

Madison nipped his bottom lip when she peeled back from the kiss. “What makes you think I would ever do something like that?”

Kane smirked. “Because you love attention more than you’ll ever let on.”

“Can you imagine what the ladies at the literary society would say if they knew I posed naked for a room full of strangers?” she replied, slipping into her Melissa role. She didn’t think anyone was close enough to eavesdrop—except for the team outside—but one could never be too careful. “In a sex club?”

“No one said you had to be naked, but I encourage it.”

“*Heads up, Sergei Reznikov is here with his friends,*” Bristow buzzed in their ears over comms. The Deputy Director was back again to take a more hands-on role with the mission.

They’d barely gotten the invitation when Kane spotted the Russians crossing the room toward them. He muttered, so only the team could hear, “A little more warning would have been nice.”

“Melissa, yes?” Sergei said in his thick Russian accent, with the cocky grin of a man who never heard *no*. His father had the same smile. “Zay’s friend?”

The black leather harlequin mask did nothing to disguise the Russian. He would have stood out in any crowd. His thick black hair carried garish blonde highlights, and his jacket was a dull mustard color. Nox Venari was strictly black tie for its male members, but Sergei’s ugly outfit technically qualified. He would have been handsome if he wasn’t trying so hard, Madison thought.

“Yes. Hi. I remember you from the other night. I’m sorry, I don’t recall your name. That was a crazy night.”

“Sergei.”

“Right, Sergei. Sorry.” Madison smiled and shrugged like things slipped her mind all the time, playing the well-meaning housewife. “This is my husband, David. Did you guys meet?”

Sergei gave a polite nod, but he treated Kane with the same dismissive attitude as Zaydan. “*Da*, your husband. Zay told me about him. That was a—as you said—*crazy* night, wasn’t it?”

His predatory grin suggested that Zaydan had shared everything that happened in the upstairs room at Nox Venari that night. *They probably had a good laugh over the slutty MILF and her cuck husband*, she thought. Whatever strange, dangerous attraction she had to Prince Zaydan, she was happy to help rid the world of men like him. But for now, she maintained Melissa Richardson's polite smile.

"Yes, it was."

"Zay was unhappy you stood him up the next night. We all missed you."

"That's sweet. I hope I get a chance to apologize to him. Will he be here soon?" She hated the superior look he gave as a reaction. She knew he was thinking, *This American slut is desperate for it*.

"Da, soon. We will get drink while we wait. Yes?"

"Honey?" she asked, turning to Kane.

"Sure, if you want to," he replied. Kane found it difficult to maintain his role as affable David Richardson when these men treated him like a useless accessory.

"Very good," Sergei said, taking Madison's arm.

MADISON WAS RELIEVED when Cassandra informed them that Prince Zaydan had arrived. The last hour had been torturous. Sergei Reznikov had many of his father's mannerisms, but none of his style or charm. Anatoly was a pig, but he had the sense to wrap it in velvet. He had aspirations to be more than he was. Sergei was just an entitled little shit and a thug.

A woman like Melissa Richardson wouldn't have spent more than five seconds with someone like Sergei. But Melissa was supposed to be horny enough for the prince that she would stick it out.

They were sitting on a long, curved couch in the downstairs lounge when the young prince entered—and he certainly knew how to make an

entrance. Zaydan walked in, one hand in his trousers pocket, paused to look around, and smiled when he spotted his friends—but his magnetism meant that people noticed when he entered a room, even when he was not trying to attract attention. With his thick, swept-back mass of hair and strong jaw, he was already handsome. Somehow, wearing his custom black mask made him even more alluring.

Madison was discomfited by the way her pulse skipped up when she saw him. The brocade tuxedo jacket, with its subtle electric-pink patterns, would have been ostentatious on anyone else, but he made it work.

Kane wanted to punch Zaydan the moment he entered the room. The way the Kharabati royal made Madison come flashed into his mind. Zaydan may have been a funder of international terror networks, but the possessiveness he showed toward Madison from the moment they met bothered him even more.

“I see you started the party without me,” Zaydan said, wearing a million-dollar smile that implied that nothing bothered him.

“Just keeping your...keeping Melissa company,” Sergei said, seeming to pause when he realized her husband was standing right there.

She wasn’t technically Zaydan’s anything. Not that men like Sergei and Zaydan respected David Richardson’s position. He hadn’t even been given a seat on the couch. Sergei and his friends took up all the room.

“I’m sure sweet Melissa never lacks for company when she wants it. I’ve seen the men here flock to her,” Zaydan replied, again disrespecting her husband. She had built-in company. She was not a single woman. “Does anyone need a refill?”

“I’m good,” Sergei replied. His lackies all mumbled the same.

Kane, fuming about his perceived irrelevance, said, “I’ll have another. It’s the Macallan Lalique VI. Do you need another, sweetheart?”

Madison considered asking for another cocktail, but it was going to be a long night, and she would need all her faculties. “I’m still working on this

one, honey.” She had to look up over her shoulder to address him. She thought Kane was handling his irrelevance surprisingly well.

Zaydan nodded to his man, Rami, who went to the bar to fetch the drinks for his master. Of course he wasn’t getting them himself. He stepped forward, and Sergei shot his friends a look. They slid down the couch, knocking the last man off, to make room beside Madison for the prince. She smiled and turned to hug him.

“I’m so sorry we didn’t make it back last weekend. We had a family thing we couldn’t get out of. You know how it is, sometimes real life has to come first,” Madison told the prince.

Not only did Zaydan accept her embrace, but he held onto her. She tried to make it a friendly greeting hug, as someone like Melissa surely would have, but he hung on, beard brushing her cheek and his breath hot on her neck. His fingers played across her bare back, dipping into the back of her dress just above her crack.

“I’d say you know what you missed out on,” he said in a low, breathy whisper that only she could hear. “But you couldn’t possibly. I am hoping that tonight, Melissa, you will receive a taste of it.”

His lips brushed her earlobe, sending a serious shiver down Madison’s spine. He pulled back from her slowly, skimming his hand over the nearly-exposed side of her breast as he did. As much as she wanted to laugh at his arrogance, she thought he just might have the skills to back it up, and she felt an involuntary tightening of her core.

Madison’s cheeks were hot when he pulled back from her, and his hungry smile said that he knew the effect he’d had on her. She hated being so transparent. He kept a hand on her bare thigh when he sat back. She placed hers over his to keep him from sliding it up her dress in front of everyone—not that it would have been a long trip.

The dress she’d chosen for their third outing to Nox Venari was the most daring yet. Even playing a role, she couldn’t quite believe she was

wearing it in public. It wasn't a cocktail dress. It was lingerie. It was all sheer black lace, except for the black satin that draped across her hips. The dress was backless, so Madison had to be braless. Only modesty netting on the inside of the dress kept her breasts from being completely exposed.

"I hope it was nothing serious," Zaydan said, as his public reply.

"No, just something with the kids. Even when they're adults, it's always something."

"I am sure. I must admit..." he paused to seriously drink her in. "It's difficult to imagine you rushing off to mend a scraped knee when you are dressed like that."

"This isn't the real me, Zay. This is...a fantasy. It's an indulgence for us. Dave and I felt like we could try to live adult lives now that our children are on their own. Well, mostly, anyway." She added a little laugh, the kind her suburban friends would echo. She also reached back for Kane's hand.

Kane took her hand, clasp ing it, feeling possessive the way a real husband would. He was standing behind the couch, lurking over the group like a bodyguard. He supposed that he was Madison's protector in this situation. His gaze keyed in on Zaydan's hand on her thigh.

Jealousy was acid in his gut, but he felt that old stirring in his tuxedo pants, too. He'd always had a love-hate relationship with watching her on their mission. It was something he didn't understand. He refused to accept that he could actually be like the man he was playing—someone who liked to watch his woman with other men. Kane saw that as weak.

"They are adults. They make bad decisions sometimes and need our help, but they're adults. But you know how mothers are, right? They'll always be kids to Mel," Kane said.

"*Da*. My mother was very overprotective. Always hovering. The times with my father were a relief. He offered me freedom to become a man," Sergei said.

“Did you lose your mother?” Madison asked, trying not to stiffen at the mention of the Russian’s father.

“She left when I was a teen. My father said she ran off with some Westerner. He said I was lucky that I didn’t have her smothering me anymore.”

“That still must have hurt,” she replied sympathetically. “At least you had your father. It sounds like you admire him greatly.”

Sergei smiled, but it was ice-cold. “He taught me the way of the world. I would not be man I am today without him.”

Rami returned with drinks for Kane and his boss. Zaydan lifted his.

“Enough maudlin parent issues. Let us toast to new friends and indulgences,” Zaydan said.

“Don’t be mean, Zay,” Madison chided. She wanted Sergei to continue. He was finally talking about something useful.

“And business. We will find time for business, yes?” the Russian added.

“Of course, that is why we’re here, is it not?” Zaydan replied.

“*Ooo*, that sounds exciting. I can’t imagine what kind of business you’d conduct here. Is this one of those secret international deals?” Madison hoped she sounded naïve enough.

The group toasted and drank. Madison feigned that the drink went down harder than it did. Zaydan had no idea how much alcohol she’d actually had that evening—a fact she planned to use to her advantage.

Zaydan grazed the lace edge of her dress with his fingertips. “I’ll share my secrets if you share yours, Melissa.”

She returned his smile. “That’s an offer I just might be interested in.”

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Madison and Kane finally got a glimpse of the Obsidianus lounge on the third floor of Nox Venari. Obsidianus membership came with a steep price tag—\$75,000—and was invitation-only. The Ludolfs wanted to be sure members at that level could observe the highest levels of discretion and privacy. Obsidianus members could bring their guests to the VIP area if they were willing to take responsibility for those guests' behavior.

It had been clear from the start that Prince Zaydan bin Zaman al-Kharabati—and his family's billions in petrodollars—commanded the highest level of service at Nox Venari. Kane suspected the man could murder someone in the VIP lounge, and it would be handled. For all he knew, the prince had.

Zaydan escorted Madison, his hand on her bare back, then her ass, as they went. Kane brought up the rear, with only Rami the bodyguard behind him. The spy knew he was only grudgingly invited to join the group. He was only brought along when Madison reached out her hand for him, making it clear she wasn't going anywhere without her "husband."

The difference in being an Obsidianus member was obvious the moment they cleared security and walked up the stairs to the third level. The lounge was through a wide door on the left. It was like they stepped into another world.

The lighting was even more subdued than on the floors below, making it impossible to see what occurred in the private alcoves along the walls. Those walls were not the mahogany panels that were in some of the rooms below, but jet black marble, with veins so fine they were barely visible in the low light. The Obsidianus lounge had its own bar at one end and a curtained stage at the other.

Kane found himself on the outside looking in once again—literally this time. The small, curved alcoves could seat only four people comfortably. Zaydan swept Madison into one with him, and Sergei and one of his flunkies followed, leaving everyone else to fend for themselves. Sergei's other companions went to the bar, while Rami stood just outside of the alcove.

When Kane moved to see if he could squeeze into the alcove with the others, Rami put a hand on his chest. The burly man looked like he could have crumpled Kane into a ball and tossed him away, but he still tensed, his first instinct to fight rather than back down.

Beyond the bodyguard, he saw Madison nestled tightly between Zaydan and Sergei. The prince's arm was around her. The Russian brushed her bare thigh with the back of his hand. The semi-darkness made it difficult to discern what was happening, even when he stood just outside the alcove. Kane's anger surged. He felt like the wallflower whose girl had just been taken by the cool guys. He understood his role, but he didn't think David Richardson would just step back either.

"That's my wife," he said, his low tone an implied threat.

"There is no room," Rami replied.

Kane pushed against the hand. It had no give. He thought about the knife concealed in his boot and stood his ground.

"Buddy..."

"*Stand down, Kane,*" Bristow buzzed in his ear. "*Don't make a goddamned scene. I think we're getting close. Go get a drink and cool off.*"

Kane backed off, raised his hands, and smiled. “I’m gonna go get a drink. I’ll be back.”

Rami gave him a look that said, *sure you will*.

Bristow was right, but Kane still wanted to tell her to go fuck herself. He’d always had trouble staying objective when Madison was involved. It was the reason he’d come so close to getting killed so many times when they were partners.

BEING PRESSED between the two villains felt *cozy*. Madison kept reminding herself that Zaydan was one of the bad guys because when they were so close, and she felt his hard body under that expensive, custom-tailored tuxedo, and caught his spicy, masculine scent, she did not think of him as someone she might need to kill. The gentle throb between her thighs filled her mind with different thoughts entirely.

Madison hoped that she wasn’t there as just a bit of fun—mostly—but that the men were finally ready to discuss business. She thought she’d done a good job of acting like someone they could speak freely around. She’d sold them on the idea that she was pretty tipsy.

“This place feels different,” she said, awe in her voice. “Kind of dangerous.”

“You’re not in any danger with us, Melissa,” Zaydan said. He worked his hand past her arm and caressed her breast.

Her breath caught. It was not part of the performance. “I’m not so sure about that. Where is Dave?”

“He is getting drink, I think,” Sergei answered. He laid his hand firmly on her inner thigh.

“I’m sure he’ll be right back,” Zaydan added.

Madison pulled her thigh away from Sergei, but there wasn't much room to move. Melissa would not let the Russian grope her. She'd established a relationship with Zaydan—such as it was—but she barely knew Sergei. The proper suburban mom she played wouldn't just let him touch her. Not yet.

"Did you enjoy our night together last weekend?" Zaydan asked. He plucked her nipple through the lace, catching it between two deft fingers. The pressure made her whimper.

"Yesss...*but*..." Her breathy tone sounded like surrender.

"Please don't tell me you're having second thoughts, Melissa?" He didn't stop touching her to wait for an answer.

"No. I...*ohhh...I just...Zay*..."

"You can tell me anything." The prince grinned wolfishly.

"Sorry, it's hard to think when you're doing...*mmm...that*..."

"Doing what?"

His amusement made Madison want to yank his hand off her chest. His touch felt good, but she wasn't as helpless as she pretended. Melissa was losing it. Madison held onto her control—for now.

"*Touching me...mmm...like that...on my...breast*..."

"Shall I stop?"

"*I didn't...mmm...say that... But this isn't...ahhh...me... I don't... mmm...do this*..."

"Oh, Melissa, you'll find yourself doing everything tonight."

Before she could answer again, Zaydan turned her to kiss him. Whatever aromatic liquor he'd been drinking made his mouth sweet, spicy, and delicious. She hungrily returned the kiss, pressing her tongue into his mouth for more.

Sergei slid his hand up under her dress, brushing against her damp panties before she could clamp her legs shut. The move only pinned his hand against her apex. She rolled her hips, working her mound against his

fingers while she devoured Zaydan's kiss. She was every bit as overwhelmed as Melissa Richardson would be. It had been too many years since she had two men touching her at the same time.

Madison grabbed Sergei's wrist, but he didn't let her pull his hand away. She tightened her grip and dug her nails in, belying Melissa's role as a bewildered submissive in the world of Nox Venari. Or maybe she just did a lot of Pilates. The Russian grunted and withdrew his hand.

"Zay..." she panted, her wet lips sticking to his. She chased another kiss, like she didn't really want to stop. She didn't. Playing coy was getting harder.

"Yes, darling?" he sounded as breathless as she did, which only made her want him more.

"We can't...*I* can't...do this here."

"Do you want me to stop?"

Madison gave a sharp cry when he pinched her nipple harder, making it throb. She kissed him again. She kept telling herself it was all about the mission as she raked her nails through his impossibly thick, black hair. Guilt faintly echoed in the back of her mind. She'd put her real life in a lockbox to get through the mission, but the heat that Zaydan generated in her melted that lock. If she were just doing her job, she wouldn't like it so much.

A familiar posh British accent floated through the room, amplified by hidden speakers. Madison pulled away from the kiss once again—even more reluctantly—to see Syma standing on a small stage at the front of the room. It had been obscured by the black velvet curtain.

Syma, the stunning, curvy woman on the stage, was the person who greeted Madison and Kane for their membership interview at Nox Venari. With the stylized black leather mask, featuring the tiny silver fox's head that was the symbol of the club, Madison thought she could be mistaken for Priyanka Chopra Jonas. She didn't watch much TV, but the actress had been

in two spy shows, and she always liked to check those out. Neither of Priyanka's portrayals was convincing.

"I hope everyone is experiencing the night of their lives here at Nox Venari, especially here in the Obsidianus lounge," Syma continued. She spoke into a wireless microphone. "If there is anything we can do to make our evening more memorable, please see your concierge and we will move heaven and earth for you."

Could you drop Null:Echo into my lap before I cross a line I can't uncross? Madison wondered.

"As you all know, we have a tradition here at Nox Venari. It's a special occasion downstairs, but we do this every weekend for our Obsidianus members. The clock has struck midnight, which means it's time for the auction."

Madison realized she was still holding on to Zaydan. One hand clutched his jacket. She still played with his hair with the other. He really did have amazing hair. She gently took her fingers out of it. He didn't seem like a man who wanted his carefully coiffed hair disturbed, but he was eager enough for her to let it slide.

"What is the auction?" she asked.

"I'm not sure I can explain it well. Perhaps you should see it for yourself. Sergei is a fan. Who did you get last Saturday?" Zaydan asked.

"Was all-American girl named Megan. Very sweet. Very pliant." He had a sour look. He resented Madison's rebuff.

"Yes, I remember now. She was quite the catch. A real prom queen type, like in your American movies. Were you a prom queen, Melissa?"

His hand continued caressing her breast and toying with her nipple. It was a constant distraction. The casual way he touched her was a turn-on itself. It was like he'd already decided he owned her. Madison didn't think about why she liked that so much.

A tall, slender black girl appeared in the entrance to their alcove. She was stitched tightly enough into a black leather corset to juice modest cleavage from her small breasts. All Madison could think was how painful that must be. The girl took their drink orders and disappeared again.

“I was Alpha Beta Cappa,” she finally answered. “And I was a cheerleader, but I was never the prom queen.”

Zaydan smiled like he was imagining her with a sash and a crown. She saw an entitled man like him asking her to dress as a prom queen, which would be silly. “Your schoolmates don’t know what they missed out on. I do not believe any girls outshone you.”

“Becky Samuels was not going to let anyone else near that crown. Besides, I didn’t even enter. I don’t seek the spotlight.”

“Ah, but it seeks you,” Zaydan replied.

“Our first item up for offer is Megan,” Syma said from the stage.

A pretty, buxom blonde stepped out onto the small, circular stage. She certainly looked like a Midwestern prom queen by way of an old-school *Playboy* centerfold. Madison remembered Billy McManus sneaking his dad’s dirty magazines, and they would all stare at them like flipping through *Playboy* was something a sophisticated adult did. She never thought she would look like one of those women.

A harsh white light clicked on directly above Megan, isolating her. She smiled, but Madison saw her shifting uncomfortably.

“We will start the bidding at five thousand dollars,” Syma announced.

“Do you plan on a repeat performance, my friend?” Zaydan asked the Russian.

“*Nyet*. I have what I need from her. And she gave it to me very sweetly,” he replied.

Madison stiffened, deciding she would never let Sergei touch her again.

A man shouted from one of the alcoves. Syma raised the bidding, and another man took the bait.

“What is this, Zay? What is going on?” Madison asked.

“The auction is a time-honored tradition at the club. No one told you about it when you joined?”

“I think I would have remembered that.” She tried to shrug his hand off her breast, but he did not let go easily. Feeling so aroused while they discussed literally auctioning off women felt wrong.

“Oh, don’t be distressed. These women haven’t been kidnapped. They are all willing participants.”

“Why? Why would they do that?” It was a question Melissa would ask. Madison knew the answer.

He paused to formulate a diplomatic answer. It was accepted that Nox Venari hired models as escorts to ensure they had a supply of beautiful people for the club. Everyone assumed that the club did its due diligence and tested for STDs, and they were safe if they made a connection with one of the models. But it was not spoken about. Pretending the beautiful people were just part of the club was part of the illusion.

“For various reasons. They ask for volunteers. You could go up for auction if you were the type to seek the spotlight.”

Madison gave Melissa’s shocked reaction and said, “And then what happens?”

“Whatever the buyer wishes, of course,” Zaydan dismissively replied. “Of course, there are safe words, and one can communicate what is off-limits, but is that really in the spirit of the game?”

“I can’t imagine...being sold...just letting anyone who wanted...do anything to me...”

“Can’t you? Can’t you imagine giving up control, Melissa?”

Madison had never been sold, but she’d certainly been rented in her career. And she’d often had to let men do as they pleased. She’d always justified it to herself as necessary, refusing to confront the idea that perhaps there was a reason she was so good at that sort of work.

“Not like... I could never be *auctioned*.”

While they chatted, Megan was sold for \$14,000. The next woman up for auction looked like a runway model—young, incredibly slim, with high cheekbones and no curves at all. She wore a gossamer shift that was completely sheer. The bidders saw everything. Madison would have sworn the girl wasn't much older than Penny. Only the girl's haughty attitude stanchied Madison's instinct to protect her. She knew a mercenary attitude when she saw one. She'd had it herself at that age.

Zaydan drew her lips to his. The kiss was slow, teasing, with lots of flicks of tongue. He knew exactly what he was doing. She chased his lips, but he didn't let her catch them right away.

“I look forward to discovering how many things you think you'd never do, darling.”

“Zay...”

The hand that pushed up under her dress did not belong to Sergei that time. Zaydan's knuckles pressed hard against her cleft, and Madison swooned against him, undone by the sudden surge of ecstasy that flowed out from her center.

“*God...Zay...what...ohhh...*”

He rubbed his knuckles up and down her slit, her silk panties the only barrier between them. Each time they pressed her clit, a deep moan escaped her lips.

“Did you ever expect you would let a man touch you in public like this, Melissa?”

“*Mmm...Zay...*”

She rolled her hips, seeking the pressure. She didn't even pretend she didn't want it.

“A man you hardly know?”

Madison bit her lip and shook her head. She looked away from him because she didn't want him to see the need in her eyes.

“You’re going to come on my hand, Melissa. Right here.”

“*I...Zay...I ca...*”

“Don’t tell me you can’t. You will. Unless you stop me.”

His arrogance was fuel on her fire. He’d seen that part of her that wanted to be told what to do, and he was happy to exploit it. She was exactly the kind of woman men like him sought.

Madison heard Sergei snort beside her. She knew exactly what it meant. *Little slut pushes me away but lets him do as he pleases with her.* His animosity was dangerous. Either the Russian would decide she was beneath him and not worth a second thought, or he was plotting his revenge for being spurned. She’d have to keep an eye on him.

The girl brought their drinks, but she was ignored. Madison was too busy trying to fuck Zaydan’s closed hand. The auction continued, but it was a background blur. He could have made her come quickly—she was horny enough for it—but he drew it out, making her suffer. She kissed him throughout, to muffle her moans if for no other reason. But when she was close, she lay her head on his shoulder, panting.

“Yes...there you go...come for me, darling. You’re so ready, aren’t you?” he whispered.

“*Yeah...yesss...Zay...I...please...*”

Sergei was calling out. Madison thought he was bidding on someone. She didn’t care. Zaydan was right. She was close. She needed to come.

The prince gave her nipple a much harder twist and thrust his fingers deep, grinding with the rest of his hand. That did it. Madison bit into his shoulder—hard. The padding in the shoulder of his ornate tuxedo jacket was the only thing that spared him from teeth marks. She shouted into her mouthful of brocade and trembled, locking her thighs around his hand. The climax came in pulses, and she shouted into Zaydan again.

Madison almost resented how hard he made her come because she knew the entire team heard it. *Bristow* heard it. They could say whatever they

wanted about understanding that she was doing her job. She knew they didn't think of her the same after what they'd seen her do. And coming so easily for the enemy was just another strike to add to their mental files.

"Feels so good to give in, doesn't it?" Zaydan cooed, somehow sounding both soothing and condescending at the same time.

She bit back her Madison response—*fuck you*—and instead told him, "That was *a lot*. *Ohmygod*. I think my heart almost stopped. You have to stop moving your hand, Zay..." Her voice was all trembly and breathy. It was not an act.

Zaydan looked over her to Sergei. "Sounded like you got some business done while we were busy. Did you get what you wanted?"

The Russian's laugh was cold. "Thick, pretty Spanish girl. We'll soon see if she is what I'm looking for."

"I know you have particular tastes, my friend."

"Speaking of business. I do not want to disrespect your hospitality, my prince, but my people are getting, how they say here—antsy. We must close this deal."

"Yes, yes, I know, Sergei. My brother is also eager to get this done. If your Glacier Flame friends can give the assurances we seek, I believe we have agreed on price, give or take ten million or so."

Madison looked between the two men. Luckily, having just come made it easier to look bewildered. Sergei did not look pleased that Zaydan said the name of the hacker group that developed Null:Echo out loud—even in the very private confines of the Obsidianus lounge.

"Give or take ten million...*or so*?" What are you selling—aircraft carriers? Oil?" Madison worked to sound impressed.

"Don't worry yourself with this," Zaydan said. "It's just boring stuff. I have much more exciting pursuits to keep us occupied."

"*Da*. Bad things can happen when the wrong people pay too much attention," Sergei added. He did not sound playful like the prince.

“Sorry, I’m just curious. That’s a lot of money to be throwing around. Do you know how many kids we could teach to read with that kind of money?”

“Your husband has many large deals of his own. Don’t pretend you shop at the Walmart, darling,” Zaydan said, his thumb drawing circles over her clit again. He’d never slipped his fingers out of her.

“Dave doesn’t make *that* kind of money. There is no...*ohhh*...give or take...*mmm*...ten million in our world. *Zay, please*...”

Sergei ignored the whimpering American bitch and continued. “I believe my developers can provide all of the assurances you need.”

“All we need to see is proof of concept then, my friend. You can have the money at the push of a button. Although I guess with...” Zaydan paused before he said the words *Null:Echo*, then continued. “I guess with your tool, you don’t need me to push a button at all.”

Sergei chuckled. “*Da*, that would be proof of concept.”

Zaydan turned grim. “You do not want to even joke about touching the sovereign funds of Kharabat without the king’s permission, my friend. The Royal Guard has a very long reach.”

Madison was impressed with the prince’s ability to talk business and play with her clit so expertly. She was having trouble following the dick measuring going on in the alcove while the intense pleasure throbbed through her. But she didn’t need to. The Scarlet Phantom team was catching every word. Perhaps that could even shut this down tonight, and she could go back to her life. But maybe after she came again first.

“We will do your proof, but not here. It is not safe. I need my security before we bring the item out in view,” Sergei said.

“And my people must be present as well. I have the perfect solution. How do you feel about the beach?”

“Russians do not surf.”

“My family has a beach house not too far away—out on Long Island. It is isolated. We can all bring our friends. I’ll supply entertainment. We’ll make a weekend of it.”

“Sometimes I think you like to play too much,” Sergei said.

Zaydan smiled, but his tone was not mirthful.

“I do enjoy diversions, my friend, but do not mistake enjoying life for a lack of seriousness. Our work is life and death for our people. I enjoy the decadent pleasures of the West while they are here. I do not want to go out as a sour man like my uncle, who just vanished one day, having never enjoyed life at all. That will not be me.”

“*God...Zay...you have to stop, or...*” Madison injected herself, not just because she needed to come, but to ease the tension between the men.

“Or what, darling? Don’t worry. You’ll get the *or* very soon. Perhaps you should join our little excursion to the beach. I’m sure you’re fetching in a bikini.”

Syma appeared just outside the alcove. “Sir, Pilar is waiting for you, as soon as payment is completed.”

“*Da.*” The Russian took a black credit card from his wallet and handed it to her.

“We’ve reserved a private room for you.”

“Excellent,” Zaydan interjected. “It’s time to move this party to somewhere more private.”

“*God...Zay...*”

Madison buried her face in his shoulder. She could not look Syma in the eye while he was doing that to her. Going off with the price was a terrible idea, but she had no choice. They were so close. She was sure he had more than a quick fuck in mind. It scared *and* thrilled her.

twelve

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The playroom was bigger than the private rooms Kane had seen downstairs. Being a high roller had its perks. The wood-paneled walls were painted black. The only splash of color was the blood red area rug on the hardwood floor. Lovesats were set back from the canopied California king bed. Wall sconces provided the soft, moody lighting.

The first thing he noticed was the high, mirrored headboard. Perfect for putting on a show. He only saw that the inside of the canopy was also mirrored when he got close. It was the closest he got to the bed.

Once again, Kane was a third—or fourth—wheel.

He'd followed the others, still much too aware that he was following, and not an active participant in anything that was happening. He would have been left behind at the bar if he hadn't been paying attention.

He'd caught Zaydan leading Madison out of the lounge, followed by Sergei and one of the other Russians. Rami, the bodyguard, brought up the rear. She looked back over her shoulder at Kane, but he had the impression she was ready to leave without him.

"Where are they going?" Kane had asked, subvocalizing in a way that only the comms would pick up. He knew the team had been listening in. They were better informed than he was.

“Peacock said something about going to a playroom. But they were talking about Null:Echo. Stay with them, Kane,” Bristow ordered in his ear. *“We have no idea what could happen in there.”*

He wondered if the Deputy Director’s concern was for Madison or the cipher.

Kane wanted to protect Madison and cover his concealed camera. He’d been too in the thick of it when they’d been to the club before to think of it, but now that he was an observer, he was keenly aware that he was not the only one. The team had legitimate reasons to monitor their covert cameras, but they didn’t need to see Madison like that.

Once they were settled, Kane and the other Russians sitting to watch, Rami standing sentry by the door, Zaydan asked Pilar to strip Madison. The girl had been waiting in the room when they’d arrived, dressed in black, bondage-themed lingerie that was all straps and silver clasps. The outfit only made her curves seem more outrageous. She looked like she needed all those straps to contain her heavy tits. Kane had admired Sergei’s taste when he saw the Russian bidding on her.

“Wait? What?” Madison said. “Zay, I can... Or you can...”

Pilar moved to the redhead and reached for her dress. Sergei didn’t seem to mind the prince giving his pet a command. She probably didn’t know who’d actually won her. Most of the men bidding had been seated back in those alcoves. Her hands brushed over Madison’s soft, pale, freckled skin, and the redhead tentatively stepped back.

Madison couldn’t avoid being stripped because she was wearing so little to begin with. Pilar only needed to slip a couple of straps free, and Madison’s dress floated to the floor. Kane thought she looked damned sexy in it, but she looked even better in just her panties.

Sergei cursed in Russian. Zaydan gave a low whistle. Neither of them could keep their eyes off Madison. They separately mapped her soft, feminine curves.

The prince fixated on the swell of her hips and her perfectly smooth, waxed mound. He wanted nothing more than to plunder the treasures hidden there. Zaydan felt he'd been patient enough with her. She played the reluctant slut, putting up token resistance before she spread her legs for him. He'd let her, until now. She could have her facade of garden parties and the Literacy Society. But he saw the needy whore beneath, and he was going to bring her out tonight. He would show her husband who she truly was.

You will break for me tonight, Melissa. And then you'll beg me to do it again, he thought.

Sergei was all about her tits. He loved tits. The bigger the better, in his mind, but he liked the little ones that sat up high, too. A woman the redheaded MILF's age didn't have tits that sat high, but hers were fucking nice. They were big enough to give her a perfect hourglass. They looked so fucking soft. The Russian wanted to bury his face in them and play connect-the-dots with all those freckles. He wanted to suck on her pale pink nipples. And then Sergei wanted to—smack them. He wanted to smack them until they were red and swollen and she begged him for mercy.

That American bitch refuses me? She thinks she's too good? When I'm done, she'll beg to do whatever I want. And I'll make her cuckold husband watch. Then I shoot them in the head and dump them in the river. The thought made Sergei hard.

"You don't have to do this. If you don't want..." Madison murmured, no longer retreating, but still tense. The night was getting weirder by the second.

Pilar had a very pretty smile. Even up close, her olive skin was flawless. Under any other circumstance, Madison would have asked about her skin routine, but she was a little distracted. Their breasts brushed together—Pilar's sheathed in tight, restricting black satin.

“I want to do as I’m told, ma’am. It’s my pleasure to serve,” Pilar softly replied. Madison tried to place the accent. Peruvian?

“But I didn’t...”

Words failed Madison when the girl planted butterfly kisses down the plane of her stomach and over that little bump that would not yield to any amount of crunches—the gift of birthing two kids. She felt all trembly when Pilar kissed her there.

Madison took a deep breath and tried to recover, but her words came out as a needy whisper. “I don’t even...mmm...with women...”

Melissa Richardson had probably never been with a woman, but Madison Sinclair learned how erotic another woman’s touch could be over twenty years ago on a yacht in the deep blue Aegean Sea. That wasn’t the last time she’d enjoyed a sapphic encounter, but it had still been a lifetime ago.

Pilar knelt and rolled Madison’s panties down over her hips. The woman’s breath in Madison’s most sensitive area made her tremble and gasp. It was a promise of something more, but she still hated how easily it affected her. She was still so tender down there from how hard Zaydan made her come in the lounge.

“Don’t you, Melissa?” the prince asked. “No drunken encounters in the dorm with your roommate at Vassar after a night of Jello shots? David, do you know, has your sweet Melissa ever fucked another woman?”

Kane gritted his teeth. *Now this prick wants my input? To taunt us?* He was sure he could bury his knife in the prince’s neck before Rami or the Russians could intervene. It would mean their certain death, but it might be worth it.

“Listen,” he said, coming off the couch. Even David Richardson wasn’t going to sit still for that. The man had hung back because he was indulging his wife-watching kink, but he still had his pride.

Rami came forward from the door, and the Russians sitting around him tensed, but Kane kept moving because Richardson wouldn't have that situational awareness. Sergei looked amused, like he wanted to see this soft banker try something in a room full of hard men. He was too dim to see Kane's steel beneath the soft facade.

Kane didn't intend to actually do anything, as much as he wanted to, but he was reassured by the knowledge that the men around him couldn't be armed. Everyone was checked at the front door. Nox Venari didn't allow weapons on the premises.

"Yes?" Zaydan asked, like he would love to see Kane try to intervene. But he saw David Richardson, the venture capital investor, not the trained CIA officer.

Kane was caught short. Since he couldn't do what he wanted to do, he wasn't sure what he *should* do. It wasn't in his nature to just lay down, and he didn't think it was in Richardson's either.

"*Kane, what are you doing?*" Bristow said in his ear.

He directed his attention to Madison. "Honey, are you okay?"

Madison, who had Pilar softly kissing her thighs, was startled by Kane's question. She knew Zaydan was trying to provoke him, but it was difficult to concentrate on that when she was so aroused that she was trembling. All her energy was going into holding it together and keeping her cover intact.

"I'm good," she replied. "Everything's...*ohhhkay...isn't...mmm...it?*"

"We can stop if you insist," Zaydan told him. "But I don't think Melissa wants that. Do you, darling?"

"*Nooo...unless...*"

"See, everything is good. Go back to your seat and...watch," Sergei said. He'd placed himself between Kane and Madison. He was spoiling for a fight.

Kane's fist shook. Sergei had done everything but call him *cuck boy*. He looked past the Russian thug to Madison. Her eyes pleaded with him—*Go*

sit down. It wasn't just the mission. She wanted this. It was a dagger in his gut, but it made his balls ache. Seeing Madison put her pleasure first still did things to him that he'd never understand.

Kane retreated to the couch and sat. He decided he didn't care what any of those fuckers thought. *I'll kill all of you before this is over anyway*, he reassured himself. And then Madison's loud moan pulled him out of it.

"Ahhh...god...yesss...that's..."

Madison's eyes were closed, and she swayed as Pilar remained on her knees and deeply kissed her pussy. Zaydan slipped off his jacket and handed it to Rami, who carefully folded it over his arm. The prince stepped behind Madison and held her, with a hand on her hip and the other curling around her caress her breasts. She moaned and leaned back against him, like she'd been waiting for his support to surrender completely.

"Is she good?" Zaydan purred in Madison's ear.

"Yesss...god, yesss..."

"Should we tell her to make you come?"

"Zay...I don't...I don't know... With...ohhh...all of you here...I..."

Pilar gripped Madison's ass to hold the redhead tightly against her mouth. Juicy sounds floated up from between Madison's thighs. A needy moan came from deep in her chest.

"I think everyone should see you surrender to your desires, Melissa. Such an amazing moment should be witnessed."

Madison wanted to give him what he wanted. There was a time when she thrived on being the center of attention like this, but she'd buried that side of herself a long time ago. Melissa Richardson certainly wasn't looking for that, but how in control would she have been at that point? Melissa would probably be overwhelmed.

"Please...Zay... oh god...not in front...of...mmm..."

"Kick your damn flunkies out. My wife isn't a goddamn show," Kane said, voice hard.

Zaydan's smile faltered. "Fine, Sergei, send your pals out to find their own fun."

Sergei nearly refused. Taking orders didn't sit well with him, especially from a spoiled American. He didn't feel much better taking them from Zaydan either. He respected the prince's goals, but the man was soft, raised in a cocoon of wealth and privilege. Zaydan saw himself in some grand struggle against the evil West, but the hypocrite indulged in all the same vices.

Ideology didn't motivate Sergei. He came by his hatred of the Americans honestly. He'd never forgive them for what they did to his father. Anatoly Reznikov survived the attack by the Americans, but he was never the same afterward. He made life hard on his son to prepare him for the world. Sergei was happy if the Kharabatis fucked the Americans with Null:Echo. But truthfully, it was just about the money. And Kharabat had a lot of that.

Sergei spoke to his men in Russian, and they filed out of the room. Rami closed the door behind them.

Madison laid a trembling hand on Pilar's head and eased it back from her pussy. She turned in Zaydan's arms and deeply kissed him. "Thank you for respecting my wishes." She knew it was laughable when she said it. She rubbed him where he strained his tight, tailored pants.

He brushed her hair back and seemed captivated by her deep blue eyes for a moment before he kissed her back. "I will not make you do anything, Melissa. But you will want everything."

She allowed a smile, still breathing hard. "Will I? What do you want, Zay?"

"I want those sweet lips on my cock," he replied, brushing her lips with his thumb.

Madison hungrily kissed him and unbuttoned his crisp, black shirt. Zaydan never wore a tie. Pushing it open, she raked her nails through the

black hair on his chest. It was tough to admit, but he was sexy. It was easy to want him if she chose to forget everything she knew about him. And to be Melissa, she had to.

Next, she reached for his heavy leather belt. The jeweled, gold buckle was laughably ostentatious, but she cared more about what was underneath it. Once she got his pants open, she reached into them and squeezed what she found. *God, why does he have to be so thick?*

“Get up on the bed,” she purred, her lips against his, adding a soft, “Please.”

THERE SHE IS, Zaydan thought. *I made her into this. And now her husband is going to see what a whore he’s married to.*

Zaydan confidently stripped, proud of the way she looked at him while he did it. He looked for any sign that her husband was looking at him, too. In his mind, all these weak men were probably latent homosexuals. He wanted no part of their deviant lifestyle, but he was pleased to let them watch their wives fucked by a superior man.

The redheaded MILF looked incredible crawling onto the bed between his legs. Her mature tits hung perfectly when she leaned forward. The hunger in her eyes made his balls tighten. She was desperate for it. There would be no running out of the room for her tonight. He was going to enjoy Melissa Richardson at his leisure. And after that? He had a few more weeks in New York to teach her the real meaning of devotion. *David won’t even recognize the woman I return to him*, he thought.

Madison slowly pumped his beautiful, dark cock. A drop of excitement formed on the tip. She didn’t generally think of dicks that way, but Zaydan had a beautiful cock. Maybe it had been too long since she’d seen a new one. It had a perfect curve, and the veins looked like they’d been etched by

an artist. It was thick enough that her fingers barely closed around it. She allowed that it probably looked bigger because he was shaved down there, but her grip didn't lie. He was big. Her core ached when she thought about him pushing it inside her.

Her tongue caught his salty precum, and she parted her red lips for him. But before she descended onto it, Charles suddenly flashed into her mind. She was filled with self-loathing.

Charles was down there in McLean, making sure their children were safe and supported, waiting for his wife to come home, concerned about the changes in her, but there she was on her hands and knees in a New York City sex club. Sucking Prince Zaydan's cock was part of her job, but the CIA couldn't make her want it as much as she did.

Madison had realized a long time ago that the Agency didn't turn her into what she'd become in the field. She had always been that eager, easy girl. Her government just decided to weaponize it against the enemy.

Zaydan still pulsed in her hand. His flesh was still hot and ready for her. That steely erection she held was all for her. She'd done that to him, and underneath the shame, she felt pride. The young prince could have almost anyone he wanted in the world, and his cock was dripping for her—a forty-eight-year-old mother of two from the suburbs. She let the pride—her need—swamp the guilt, and she got back to work.

She's making the decision, he thought. Melissa wants this so badly, but she knows he's watching and is worried he'll never see her the same way again. She should be worried. He won't. Not after the things he sees her do for me.

Her lips closed over him.

"Oh yes, darling, that's it... Those lips are amazing... So soft..." Zaydan moaned

Madison knew that Melissa Richardson probably didn't give a very good blowjob. She probably gave them as an obligation when she was

younger, and now in middle age, she blew Dave as they explored their new sexual chapter because it made her feel naughty, but she'd never developed the skills. Madison couldn't help that. She was too proud of her skills to tank it.

Kane watched Madison bob deeper and deeper on the asshole prince and felt a different, more direct flavor of jealousy. He knew exactly how good his partner was with her mouth. He had intimate knowledge of the hungry suction Zaydan was feeling, the way she worked her inquisitive tongue. He had to adjust himself in his tuxedo pants.

Madison wasn't really his wife, but he felt the same heat he would have if things had gone differently all those years ago, and she was still his. Zaydan had probably had thousands of blowjobs, but he was losing his mind over Madison's mouth.

The redhead gripped his base tightly and pushed deep, breathing through her nose when his thick head pressed into the back of her throat. She hadn't had to work to accommodate a large cock in a long time, but it all came right back to her.

Madison was a natural cocksucker. She looked up, and for the first time, she saw weakness in Zaydan's eyes. Holding him as deeply as she could, she hollowed her cheeks and sucked as hard as she could. She was in control while his cock was in her mouth.

"Yesss darling... You love a cock in your mouth, don't you? I see it in your eyes, Melissa. Uhhnn...show me...show me how deep you take it..."

Zaydan rested his hand on the back of her head, but he didn't force her. He knew he didn't need to. This woman had years of pent-up sexual need to unleash on him. She'd been someone's wife and mother for so long, but he was giving her permission to be a woman again.

Kane didn't want to see that scumbag fuck Madison's mouth, but that didn't happen. Instead, her nostrils flared, and she went so deep that her

nose nearly pressed to his pelvis. Her lips were obscenely stretched. And she held him there in her throat.

How the fuck did she take so much? Kane marveled. *Where did it go?*

By the door, he saw Rami looking like he was ready to give up Allah for one night with the sexy, redheaded MILF. Kane almost felt bad for the poor bastard. The bodyguard only ever got to watch his boss use these women. He didn't get a turn. Did he want one? Or did he want to behead the Western harlots for making his master stray from the path?

Sergei watched with admiration and contempt. He admired the Kharabati prince for getting what he wanted, but he didn't think it was such a challenge. Melissa Richardson was just another whore. She saw a man with money and dropped her panties. She saw a big cock and couldn't keep her mouth off it. He'd known a hundred women like her. *Weren't they all?*

Whores like Melissa Richardson had been his father's downfall. Some slutty failed dancer—so she'd claimed—had wrecked him. If Sergei ever caught up with that whore, he'd enjoy taking his time slicing her apart. The slutty MILF even reminded him a little of that dancer—Milica Jovanovic. He'd never forget that name. They were both redheads.

Sergei took out his aggression on Pilar. The kneeling girl gagged on his cock. He did not wait for her to show that she wanted it, the way Zaydan did with Madison, he grabbed a fistful of her lush black hair and fucked her throat. Pilar didn't resist. If anything, she sucked as eagerly as Madison.

Kane was torn. He knew his job was to sit there and watch it all happen. And he thrilled at watching Madison's feminine power. But he tensed when Sergei roughly grabbed Pilar by the hair. She's auctioned herself, that was true, but he didn't have it in him to sit there while the Russian hurt the girl—the mission be damned.

Luckily, Pilar was a willing accomplice to her debasement. She grabbed Sergei's ass and pulled him deeper into her throat, making obscene gagging noises.

“Yesss...drink it... Yesss, my thirsty darling, drink every drop...” Zaydan moaned, gripping the sheets with both hands and thrusting his hips at Madison’s mouth. His eyes rolled back in his head while the eager MILF swallowed every drop he offered.

She’s still got it, Kane smirked.

thirteen

. . .

Bristow was uneasy, watching Madison at work on the monitor in the surveillance van. The redheaded officer was still licking and kissing the target's cock, even though he'd already finished in her mouth. Bristow was intimately familiar with Madison's file—including the confidential notes that had been added during her time in the field—but she still found her officer's *dedication* impressive.

Despite the confidence she'd expressed to everyone involved, she'd had serious doubts that Madison could come off a desk and perform in the field after sixteen years. She was the Deputy Director, but she still had to fight to justify her decision on such an important operation. The problem wasn't as much Madison's field readiness as the type of operation. There were grave concerns that as a married woman with children, she could engage Prince Zaydan bin Zaman Al-Kharabati and do what needed to be done.

"Nothing in her profile suggests she's still the woman who we used to send into the field," one of the senior, *male* department heads insisted. "The background checks show no signs of infidelity over the course of her marriage. Do you think a happily married woman will be able to bring herself to cheat on her husband?"

Bristow didn't even dignify the question with an answer in the meeting, except to say she was confident Madison Sinclair was a professional and

would do what needed to be done when the time came.

Still, watching the redhead do it was a visceral experience. Over her years with the Agency, Bristow had found that sending someone out and asking them to make a deep sacrifice for their country was the easy part. Watching them make the sacrifice—especially in real time—was the hard part. She'd watched the video footage of Madison during her other visits to Nox Venari, but now Bristow was there in the van watching it happen.

The tension in the van was thick. No one spoke, but she heard Manny breathing hard in the chair in front of her. Another was available, but both she and Cassandra stood and watched the monitors. She couldn't speak for the other woman, but Bristow was too wound up to just sit there and watch it all unfold. Cassandra was like a statue. She tried to remain detached, but arousal gnawed at the edges of her consciousness. It wasn't an indictment of her professionalism. She was only human.

Zaydan rolled Madison onto her back and shoved his hand between her thighs. Her moan came through the comms loud in their ears. They had two views of the action, although only one of them gave the full picture—the camera concealed in one of Kane's shirt studs. He gave them a three-quarter view of Madison on the bed—a front row seat to her government-sanctioned depravity.

The other camera was concealed in a heart-shaped locket around Madison's neck. It was the only thing she wore besides her heels and a few rings. The camera shot was nauseating if one stared at it too long, as it bounced with her movements. But it provided for some interesting views. The prince's cock looked positively gigantic when it was coming right at her. And then she was too close, and it only showed flashes of flesh-colored light.

"Zay...please...god...that's...sooo..."

Bristow would have been embarrassed for her officer if she were still capable of embarrassment. Madison was playing a role, but it was clear to

anyone who watched her—heard her—that the arousal, the need in her voice, was entirely real. No one was that good of an actress.

“So, what, Melissa? Tell me, I know what you want. Your cunt is dripping for it,” the prince demanded in a low rumble.

“Sooo good... It feels so fucking good, Zay... I want...”

“Yes, get filthy for me. Tell me...”

On their monitors, they saw Zaydan pumping his hand, fingering her hard. Bristow wondered how many fingers he had in her. Her own core tightened at the thought of being that horny. It had been much too long since she’d felt anything like that. Her ex-husband certainly didn’t get her there.

Manny grunted in front of them. Bristow laid her hand on his shoulder, and he shuddered. *He better not have just...* she thought. “Keep it in your pants, Sanz,” she told him. She wasn’t unsympathetic. It was like they were all watching porn together.

“I want you...Zay...I want you...”

The prince kept fingering her, wanting more. His arrogance made Bristow want to rush into that room and shoot him herself.

“Fuck me... I want you...I need you...to fuck me... God...fuck me... now!”

“That’s the dirty slut I wanted to see, Melissa! The needy whore with her dripping cunt, not the bake sale mom!”

“God...Zay...why... Just do it...Stop talking...and do it!”

Zaydan hiked Madison’s legs up over his forearms, and he slammed his cock deep with one stroke. Her wail was so loud that Bristow almost tore out her earpiece.

“Yes!” he growled. “Fuck yes!”

Don’t be so cocky. You’re obviously on dick pills, Bristow thought. No man recovered that quickly in real life. But still, she saw what he had, and

she wouldn't have minded feeling it herself—if it had been attached to anyone else.

JESUS, Kane thought, watching Zaydan pound Madison. *Thank god she's not really my wife*. He felt guilty the moment the thought crossed his mind. It was unfair. But even as a man just pretending to be her husband, it was a tough watch.

He wasn't the type to take his cock out in front of other men, but it needed relief. His balls were throbbing from watching Madison in action. He hoped Zaydan wanted to watch him fuck her again. She clearly needed to be fucked—really fucked—no matter how happy she claimed to be at home, but Kane didn't think he was getting back inside her otherwise. With him, she'd find the strength to behave herself. He saw the guilt she carried over that night they gave in to their passions. He wouldn't push her again.

The large bed was sturdy, but it still protested under the strain. Zaydan was in good shape, and he was using all of that power to pound Madison. He held her hips and her legs, slung over his arms, bounced like they were made of rubber. Only the ankle straps kept her heels from flying off.

Kane tried to think back. It was a long time ago, but he couldn't recall watching Madison take it like that before. But then, he hadn't seen everything she did. He was often only there at the beginning and the end of an operation. He had no idea what happened when she was on the yacht in Greece for a month.

Was it possible she was even hornier, even wilder, as a middle-age mom than she was back in their heyday together?

Madison felt like she had no control. She was wailing like he was killing her. Zaydan was fucking it out of her. She dug her nails into his forearms and hung on for dear life, trying not to prove him right by coming

too quickly. She did not want him to think she really needed what he had. It didn't matter that he thought Kane was her husband and not Charles. She didn't want to embarrass either man.

"Fuck...you're tight..." Zaydan huffed. *"No wonder you're so sexed up, Melissa... You needed this cunt opened up..."*

"Stop...stop talking... Just...just do it...fuck me..." Her voice lurched with every powerful thrust. She needed the fucking—though she'd never admit it—but she didn't need the bragging. Neither of her men deserved to be put down.

"I plan...to do it...all night... Mel...issa... My cunt tonight..."

"Then...ohhh yesss...do it...stop talking and do it...fuck...my...cunt..."

Saying the filthy word was worth the shock in the prince's handsome, dark eyes. Melissa Richardson didn't talk like that. He didn't know that Madison Sinclair had a filthy mouth. She knew the team heard it, too.

"Oh my, Mrs. Richardson...do you kiss your children with that mouth?"

Madison didn't have a snappy reply. His big, powerful cock was scrambling her brain. All she could do was *feel*. Feel the way Zaydan wrecked her in a way her husband never had. Charles *couldn't* fuck her the way he did—for so many reasons. The comparison brought deep shame—but not enough to kill her need.

Zaydan leaned forward, bending her in half, and braced a hand on the headboard. The position gave him even more leverage, and it felt like he was trying to fuck her through the bed. Past him, she saw their reflection in the mirror above the bed. She couldn't believe that was her.

The woman in the mirror was flushed and desperate. She held onto Zaydan's sides like she was trying to pull him deeper, urge him to fuck her harder. Her legs were spread so wide. Her mouth hung open, like she had to let all of those wails out. Seeing herself like that snapped Madison.

"Yesss! Yesss! Fuck! Ohhh fuck yes!" she cried, staring at herself in the mirror as she detonated on Zaydan's cock.

The pleasure seared through her, leaving only throbbing, senseless pleasure in its wake. The line between Madison and Melissa blurred. It didn't matter anyway. Both were women getting taught what they needed by a cocky, merciless younger stud. He never stopped moving inside her, and every deep thrust seemed to set off a new wave of pleasure.

"You can't...deny it...any...longer... Your...cunt...is mine...now..."

"Yes! Fuck yes! Zay...I can't breathe..." Madison didn't know what she was saying yes to. She wasn't thinking clearly.

Sergei was impressed. He'd seen the spoiled prince fuck last weekend at Nox Venari, but this redheaded whore inspired him. Zaydan hadn't quite wrecked that woman. Based on the noises she was making, he thought Melissa was ready to leave her poor sap of a husband.

He glanced at the man on the couch. The bastard looked stricken. No man should ever see his woman unravel for another man like that. Sergei was sure he'd never heard those noises from his wife before. *Is this what you wanted to see, you fool? Will you jerk off to memories of your wife being taken from you?*

This was exactly why you never let another man touch your woman. There was always the chance that he would fuck your wife better than you ever could. And then she was lost to you. Sergei understood it all. He'd never be so foolish—so weak—but he understood the situation.

Sergei pulled his cock out of the whore's mouth. He didn't hurt her, but he pulled Pilar by the hair and bent her over the bed beside Madison and Zaydan. The prince had just paused long enough to flip the MILF over and pull her ass into the air before he shoved it back into her. She whimpered his name when he started in on her again.

Pilar's face was inches from Madison's when Sergei slipped inside her. He was gratified that the pretty girl was slick for him. He hated to think she was only doing it for the money.

“There you go...my friend...” Zaydan grunted, his hands full of Madison’s supple, round ass. *“Let us see...who makes their woman...come first...”*

Sergei picked up his pace. “You have headstart...” In his head, he added, *And I do not think this one is as much a whore as your redhead.*

Madison gave Pilar the side-eye. Their faces were close enough to kiss. She probably should have moved away from the girl, Melissa would have done that, but she was reeling.

Zaydan hadn’t given her a moment to catch her breath before he flipped her over and started plowing her from behind. She was reduced to gripping the sheets and trying to keep from banging her head against the headboard when Zaydan thrust into her.

“Zay...ohmygod...I...I...oh god...yesss...”

Madison’s brain was scrambled. She didn’t even try to think about the mission. It didn’t matter in that moment, unless Sergei pulled Null:Echo out of his ass on a thumb drive and handed it to Zaydan. She fully dedicated herself to enjoying being thrown around and fucked like a toy. She was already building to another orgasm.

The dangerous thrill she got from a powerful man just taking her, pounding her pussy like he was punishing her, was back with an intensity that frightened her. She’d built a life, convinced herself she’d grown into a different person, a better person, but was all that sophisticated maturity just a veneer that could be stripped away so easily?

“Yesss...Yesss, Melissa... Don’t just take it... Fuck me back... Show me you want it, my beautiful married whore...” Zaydan growled.

“Yesss...yesss...”

Madison was driving her hips back to meet his thrusts without even realizing it. Their bodies crashed together with incredible kinetic energy. Her breasts bounced hard beneath her, her nipples dragging across the soft black sheets and giving her an added thrill.

Kane watched her fuck with a dark thrill. In their years apart, he'd never found another woman who excited him the way Madison did. There'd never been another woman who captivated him so much that he'd be willing to watch her fuck just for the thrill of it. But the jealousy nearly drove him to rage. He wanted to shove that bastard aside and be the one to bring those noises out of her.

"Oh fuck!" Madison cried when Zaydan grabbed her hair and wrenched her head back. He used it to control her, like a bridle on a racehorse, and like a prized filly, she poured herself into the ride, driving back onto him even harder.

Every thrust brought a tiny sting of pain from her pulled hair. His heavy, shaved balls slapped the backs of her thighs. And just like that, she was coming again, wailing in ecstasy, giving the prince everything he demanded of her. All of the sensations combining at once drew another, even more powerful climax out of Madison.

"Fuck! Fuck! Fuck, yes!" she cried, sagging down to the mattress when she went boneless with the climax.

"Does...she...always...come...so easily?" Zaydan grunted. The question was obviously meant for Kane, but he didn't turn around to address the man. He was driving his cock even harder into Madison now that she was coming again.

"Oh fuck! Oh fuck! Zay...I...can't...you..."

Zaydan pulled out. His cock was dripping with evidence of her pleasure. He put Madison on her back again, but this time, he moved on top of her, settling his weight onto her when he slipped back inside her. He grinned when her eyes rolled back.

"Yes, Melissa... You can... Keep coming for me... Keep coming until you pass out..." His voice was weaker than before. He was finally getting winded.

The prince was impressed. He'd never been with a woman who was so responsive—certainly not one her age. Seducing other men's wives, especially proper, upstanding mothers, was his hobby, but even the ripest ones were no match for this one. Something was fundamentally different about her. She was built to fuck. Zaydan couldn't believe she'd kept it buried for so long.

Sergei watched the prince demolish the dirty MILF and considered asking to tag in. The redhead was so out of control, such a slut, that he knew she wouldn't deny him now. She'd been exposed. The slut could not deny her true nature now. Perhaps Pilar could go fuck her poor husband.

"Baby...harder...baby...just like...yeah...right there...like that...gonna make me come, baby..." Pilar cried beneath him.

The Russian wanted to hold out for a shot at the redhead, but when Pilar came under him, he knew that would be impossible. Her pussy was a vice around him. But he watched the woman losing her mind beside them as he pumped his load deep into the moaning woman beneath him.

Madison held Zaydan tight and pulled him down to kiss her. He kept driving deep inside her, his thick cock stretching her with every thrust, but the action had changed. He slowed and worked his hips. She rolled hers back up to meet him. Before, it was like he was punishing her with his cock, and she'd loved every second of it. But now it felt like he was claiming her, and the ease with which she accepted it was frightening.

Keep your eye on the prize, she reminded herself, even as she was awash in deep ecstasy. *He's a terroist and you're here to stop him, not... ohmygod, he feels so good...not let him fuck you over to his side.*

"Zay..."

The soft moan sounded like surrender, and she knew it.

"Yesss...darling...give yourself to me...you're mine now..."

"God...Zay...yesss...yesss..."

Madison hated her traitorous body for betraying her and forcing the moaned agreement out of her lips.

How long can this go on? she wondered, kissing him again. *And how much will I come apart before he's done?*

THE DRIVE back to Philadelphia had been torturously long. Madison didn't dare make any eye contact with the other members of the team. She knew what they all must be thinking, but she didn't need to confirm it. If she saw the questions in their eyes, she might have come apart.

Every undercover officer confronted the risk of getting too close to a target. It was the nature of the work. The only way to be effective was to insinuate yourself in the target's life or business. Being believable meant becoming someone else, someone capable of finding the human in the target.

Madison wasn't a sociopath. She couldn't just slip into bed with someone if she couldn't find something appealing about them—something redeemable, no matter how vile their actions were. But finding that common ground, working to support a target's goals, blurred lines. It was far too easy to be swept away and compromise your judgment.

The way the team saw her behave toward Zaydan had to make them question her judgment. She was not just doing her job when she fucked the prince. No one was that good an actor. Madison fully gave herself to him. She denied him nothing he wanted from her. More than that, she enthusiastically asked for more.

Madison had been Zaydan's slut.

Long after Sergei had tired of Pilar and left, she was still fucking Zaydan. Kane even left the room at one point. She'd barely noticed. It had been so long since she'd been aggressively taken that she couldn't get

enough of the prince and his big cock. The rest of it didn't matter while she was in that bed with him. She didn't think about Null:Echo once. Horribly, she didn't even think about Charles waiting for her at home.

So yes, in their position, Madison would wonder if the officer who did all that had been fucked over to the other side. And if she'd become devoted to Zaydan, she couldn't be trusted. But those were worries for another night. Madison just had to get back, wash Zaydan off her, and reset. In the morning, she would show the team that nothing had changed. The sex was just sex.

But god, what incredible sex it had been!

Kane was her rock through all of it. On his way out the door, Zaydan taunted him, telling her "husband" that she was all his. The cocky prince had said, "Thank you for letting me enjoy her. You can go ahead and reclaim her. Isn't that what you do?"

Madison was in a haze, trembling, sticky, and exhausted, as she lay in that bed. She knew what seeing all that did to Kane—watching her for hours. She expected him to take his shot and finish the job—add his load to the ones Zaydan had deposited in her.

Kane stood tall. He held her and asked if she was okay. He helped Madison dress and then helped her walk out of that club on shaky legs. His glare at Dentiger—acting was their driver—dared the man to say something as he held the door. Madison leaned against him on the ride south on the New Jersey Turnpike. Kane silently stayed by her side the entire time.

Madison closed the door to her bedroom in the Philadelphia condo and dropped her clutch on the bed. After gingerly peeling out of her dress, she dared to look in the mirror. *Fuck, I look used*, she thought. Her pale, freckled skin bore red marks everywhere Zaydan had manhandled her. Her hair was a mess. Her makeup was smeared—where any of it remained. The vampy red lipstick she'd chosen had been worn away hours ago. Madison had been very active with her mouth.

She winced when she sat on the bed. Everything was sore, and would be for days. The shower was calling her, but she'd been out of contact for hours. Madison had to be responsible to her family—her real life—and check her phone.

Charles would have handled any emergency. He was her true rock. It was only just setting in that giving herself to Zaydan so freely was a betrayal of her husband, whether or not she was doing her duty to the Agency. She would deal with that in the morning, too.

Once it powered up, her phone showed a single text notification from Charles. She opened the messaging app and nearly dropped her phone. The image on her phone could not be real. Madison stared at that photograph and felt her world shattering around her.

The screen showed the box of Plan B pills she'd been given by the Agency at the start of the mission. Charles had spilled it out on their bed, showing Madison that he knew there were pills missing.

He knew she'd been sleeping with someone else.

Oh fuck, he knows.

undercover wife: russian roulette



Can Madison save the world without losing her own?

When Madison Sinclair agreed to go back into the field for one more mission, she knew the risks. Her life had been very different when she'd left that life behind sixteen years ago. She'd been the kind of thrill-seeking CIA officer who chased the danger and embraced every risk because he had nothing to lose. But that was then. Before she chose a different life.

Today, Madison is a suburban soccer mom. She works the snack stand and takes her turn on the team carpool list. The life she's built with her husband, Charles, is a world away from what the Agency is asking her to return to. How does she turn from baking cookies for the school fundraiser to becoming the CIA's seductive tool in the never-ending war on evil once more?

But the stakes were too high to say no. If the deadly quantum cipher **Null:Echo** fell into the wrong hands, it could mean the end of everything Madison holds dear. There was only one answer.

Was it foolish to think she could slip into a world of seductive secrets and lies and come back to her orderly suburban world whole? How could she possibly become that woman again and return to her husband unstained? Madison walked the tightrope and thought she had it all under control until one text brought everything crashing down. He knew. Her husband knew what she'd been doing for her country.

Now Madison must look her husband in the eye and ask him to let her go back, to do the unthinkable, for the sake of the world. How can she ask a civilian, a man who never signed up for that life, to let her go when all he wants to do is hold on? Can they find their way back after letting go? Lies, seduction, and betrayals have all brought Madison to the brink. But if the Russians and the Kharabatis think they have her cornered because she's gone soft, they don't know Madison at all. There is no line she won't cross, no lie she won't tell, no throat she won't cut to get back to her family. This soccer mom is out of the penalty box!

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undercover wife

Null:Echo



She walked away from the life. Now the life needs her back.

Fourteen years ago, CIA agent Madison Sinclair left the field after a mission went fatally wrong. She chose safety: a desk job, a husband, a home in the suburbs. But you can't bury the thrill forever. Or the instincts that never really left.

Madison is asked to step into the breach one more time when a dangerous cyberweapon is offered to the highest bidder. NullEcho can break any encryption without a trace, leaving financial systems, critical infrastructure, and even weapon systems vulnerable. Such a device could change the world forever. And the Russian hackers who developed it already have a buyer.

Prince Zaydan Al-Kharabat, is the playboy scion of an oil-rich monarchy that funds terror networks all around the world. He's a dangerous man with unique, dark tastes—tastes that Madison Sinclair is uniquely qualified to exploit. She knows his world and she knows how to push the buttons of men like him.

To stop the sale, Madison must step back into the shadows and enter a world of power, desire, and deception she thought she'd left behind. But can she become that woman again and hold onto everything that matters most? And this time, the mission isn't just her life on the line. It's the world.

The clock is ticking. The price is everything. And Madison Sinclair is about to find out what's left of the spy beneath the soccer mom.

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undercover wife: nox venari



The thrilling follow up to *Undercover Wife: Null:Echo*

Madison Sinclair left covert operations sixteen years ago, and she closed the door on that life forever—or so she thought. She's worked a desk at Langley ever since, becoming a wife and mother, and a respected member of her suburban community. But when a dangerous new global threat, the cyberterrorist weapon Null:Echo, goes on the market, the CIA needs Madison back in action, whatever the cost.

Beneath Prince Zaydan al-Kharabati's international reputation as a carefree playboy with a taste for beautiful women lies a darker secret. He's at the heart of his family's efforts to train and equip a global network of terrorists, and Null:Echo would be the ultimate weapon in their arsenal. Prince Zaydan is determined to acquire the weapon at all costs, and he's chosen his favorite spot to negotiate the exchange away from prying eyes, the world's most exclusive kink club for the wealthy and connected, Nox Venari.

Prince Zaydan has one weakness the CIA can exploit. His taste for a *certain type* of beautiful woman—other men's wives. Madison Sinclair is the perfect bait for the arrogant prince. Knowing she has no choice, Madison takes the assignment, but there is one more wrinkle no one warned her about: the Agency has chosen her former partner and lover, Damien Kane, as her undercover husband! She's forced to leave her real husband and children behind to plunge into a dangerous, sexy new world.

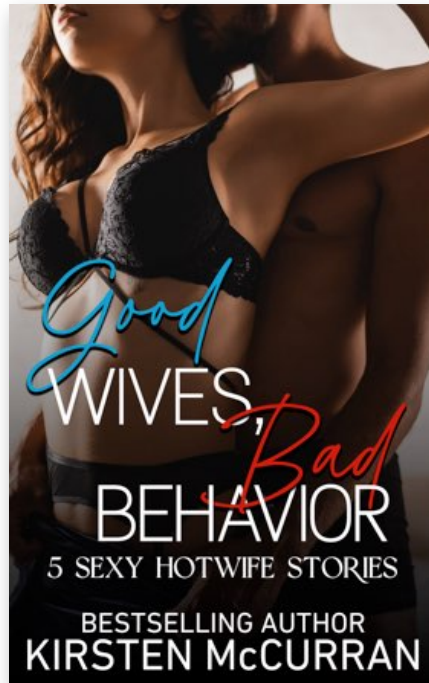
Can Madison handle the guilt of using her body to complete her mission? Will the wreckage of her past with Damien scuttle everything? How far will Madison go to keep Null:Echo out of Prince Zaydan's hands?

The clock is ticking. The price is everything. And Madison Sinclair is about to find out what's left of the spy beneath the soccer mom.

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good wives, bad behavior



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claire unwrapped



Once, she was everyone’s fantasy. This Christmas, she’s about to become her own.

At forty-eight, **Claire Weston** is a small-town celebrity. Every December she takes the stage as the leading lady in Merry Hollow’s annual Christmas play—a beloved local tradition that lets her dust off the spotlight she once knew so well. Decades ago, she played the sultry Raven Chandler on the hit soap *The Edge of Desire*. Now she teaches elementary school, tends to her marriage, and saves her acting for the holidays.

But this year’s production feels different. Her new co-star, **Ethan Blake**, is twenty years younger, dangerously charming, and very aware of who she used to be. Their chemistry is instant—and impossible to ignore. Every rehearsal runs a little hotter, every “stage kiss” lingers a little too long, until the line between acting and wanting begins to blur.

Her husband **Daniel** has always loved watching her shine, but seeing other men drawn to her stirs something unexpected—something thrilling, possessive, and just a little forbidden. And as the snow

falls and the curtain rises, Claire finds herself at the center of a passion she never expected to feel again.

Claire Unwrapped is a steamy, emotional holiday romance about marriage, trust, and the intoxicating power of being desired—on stage, and off.

ORDER YOUR COPY NOW!

the new wife on milford court



When Jeremy Sampson lands his dream job, it seems like a golden opportunity for his family. His wife, April, reluctantly gives up a life she loves for the shiny promise of a new adventure.

The Sampsons' luxurious new house on Milford Court is a dream home, but as they settle in, April can't shake the feeling that something is off about their glamorous new neighbors.

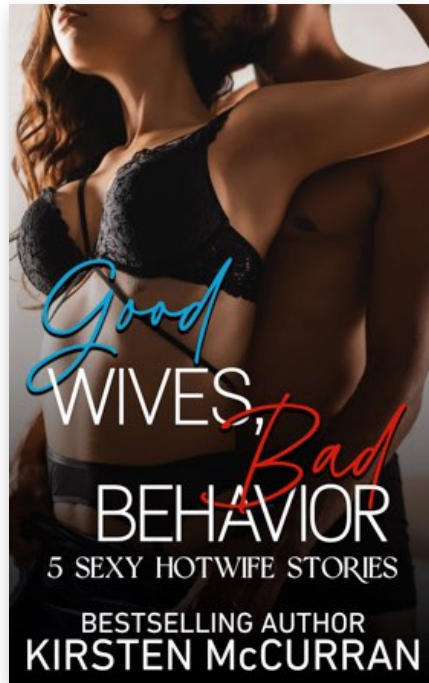
Sultry secrets lurk everywhere. April discovers the wives of Milford Court share a very special bond, one they're eager to share with her. As she delves deeper into the secrets of the gated community, April uncovers a world of forbidden temptations and dark desires.

Can April and Jeremy resist forbidden games played by the couples of Milford Court? Will Jeremy's dream job become a nightmare when he learns the real reason behind his good fortune? Get ready for a thrilling journey into the exclusive world of Milford Court, where nothing is as it seems.

The New Wife on Milford Court is the latest adventure from bestselling author Kirsten McCurran, The Queen of Suburban Secrets!

[BUY THE SERIES NOW!](#)

good wives, bad behavior



From the mind of one of hotwife erotica's most loved writers comes this bestselling collection of 5 sultry stories featuring sexy suburban couples exploring their sexuality with their friends and neighbors. These very good wives behaving very badly could be the woman you see at the grocery store or the president of your local PTA. Kirsten McCurran specializes in pulling back the curtain on everyday couples' most forbidden desires.

[ORDER NOW!](#)

picking forbidden fruit



Lauren Curry is a skilled massage therapist who finds joy in relieving her clients' pains. If anything, she's too giving, putting her clients first whenever she can. When a longtime family friend, Dylan, injures himself working for his father during college summer break, Lauren offers to treat him without hesitation.

Lauren is always the consummate professional, even when an attractive man is on her table—not that she sees Dylan as attractive. He's just a family friend. She's known the young man for ages. But once she gets her hands on the college athlete's body, Lauren discovers just how sculpted it is. Lauren admires his physique with professional detachment until Dylan turns over, and she discovers that he's enjoying her treatment *a little too much*.

Can Lauren do the right thing and keep it professional? Or will a hot college baseball player help this suburban wife find her inner cougar? Dylan is a family friend. He's forbidden fruit. Can she resist picking it?

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tara's homecoming



Tara usually passes on her husband's bro weekend with all his buddies at the Lockley University homecoming game, even though she knows all of them from their college days. She was a staple in their apartment when she started dating Mark. But it's their 20th year of tailgating, and she decides to see if the boys are as wild as they used to be.

The boys, Austin, Danny, and Shaun, were always like family to her, but Tara learns they see her very differently when their old drinking game, Heads or Tails, gets going. It doesn't matter that they're in the middle of a parking lot filled with tailgaters. The challenges keep getting wilder and more daring. Next thing she knows, Tara is crossing lines she never imagined and experiencing things she didn't think possible for a 44-year-old married woman from the suburbs.

A weekend away can change everything. Tara and Mark will be tested like never before. Can their marriage ever be the same after all their limits are shattered? **Tara's Homecoming** is another pulse-pounding shared wife adventure from celebrated author Kirsten McCurran!

ORDER NOW!

about the author

“Kirsten McCurran” is the pen name of a wife and husband team exploring the sexy secrets of middle-class, suburban couples. This couple has their own dirty little secret: they have lots of fantasies about what all their friends and neighbors are up to behind closed doors, and they turn those sexy fantasies into the stories they love to share with the world. The Mrs. could be the sweet mom you see in the stands at the soccer game or the pretty woman at the supermarket you wonder about as she's squeezing the melons. The Mr. could be your kid's little league coach.

Most of their stories are about married women looking to bust out and explore their wild side, often with the encouragement of their husbands—and sometimes without it. The strength of the couple behind Kirsten McCurran is that husband and wife writing together can uniquely capture the feelings of both partners in their couples as they explore their most forbidden desires. The Mrs. is all about exploring stories of daring women of a certain age exploring their sexuality, and the Mr. captures the feelings of the men who love them.

Kirsten McCurran has written over 60 books, which can be found at major booksellers. You can reach Ms. McCurran by email at kmccurran@gmail.com.

If you'd like other ways to support Kirsten McCurran's writing, visit her website for links, books.kirstenmccurran.com.

